

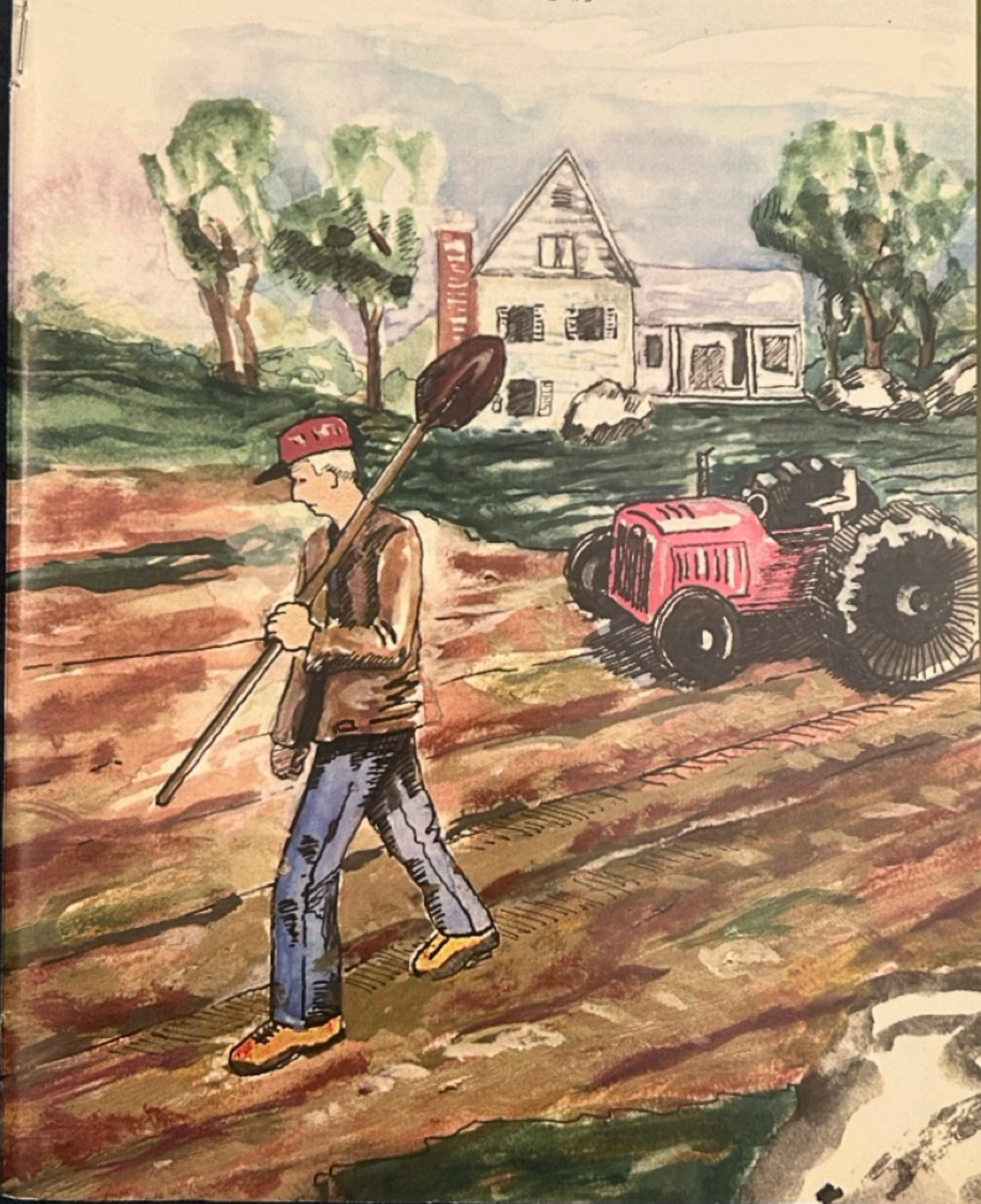
the floating liars' club

january

2003

issue #3

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shannon rampe - joe bellomy - ben criles - nathan mc knight - jade

Greetings and salutations! Welcome to the third installment of *the floating liars' club*. Things are progressing well, although we are all extraordinarily busy. Between writing, editing, and workshopping stories, and doing layout, artwork, marketing, and promotion for the magazine, we are left little time to eat or sleep.

We have received a lot of positive feedback from our readers, and the submissions have started to flow in, including interest from as far away as the U.K. We encourage anyone interested in writing to submit a piece of work. While we cannot publish everything we read, we will certainly provide feedback to anyone who requests it. While we are primarily interested in short fiction, we are also willing to look at poetry, creative nonfiction, and artwork. Submit!

This issue again features the fantastic artwork and illustration of Joe Bellomy, highlighting an interesting array of stories. While we have no intention of theme from issue to issue, this month's stories seem to congeal together nicely. Many of the stories contain the theme of discovery or uncovering things, either in the figurative sense of characters uncovering things about themselves, as in Ben Crites' "The Nature of Fireflies," or in the very literal sense as in my own story, "A Buried Mystery."

The process of writing is one of constant uncovering and discovery. Both of the stories I included in this issue were inspired by short stories I had recently discovered, namely Jorge Luis Borges' "A Secret Miracle" and J.G. Ballard's "The Drowned Giant." This process of discovery and uncovering comes from everywhere, inside and out. Part of the process of learning to be a writer is being aware of the things you are uncovering daily.

So sit back in a comfortable place with good lighting, preferably a chair, you wouldn't want to fall asleep in bed, although that's always a nice place to read, isn't it? Make sure you have something to drink at hand. Ahh, that's nice, isn't it? Now turn the page and uncover what we have wrought.

Shannon Rampe
December 2002

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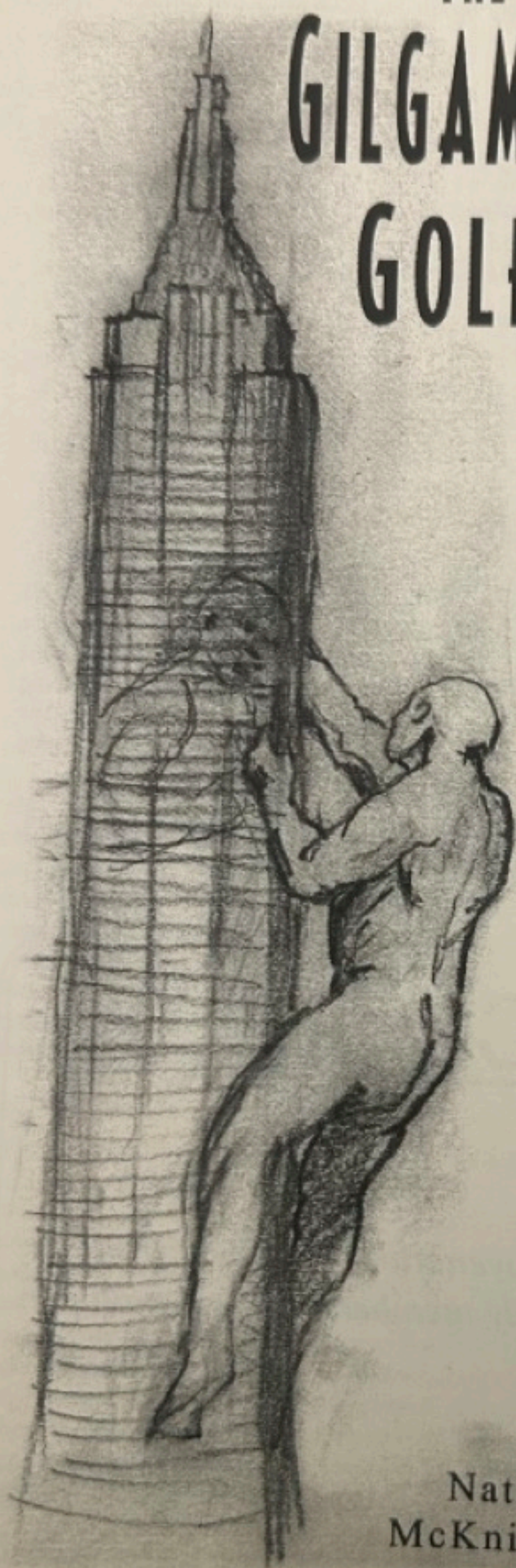
To Mom,
Enjoying
Love, Nat

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THE GILGAMESH GOLEM



Nathan
McKnight

Though I begin this story with the sincerest thought to record events as they actually happened, I owe an absolute responsibility to history to inform the reader—should there be a reader—that, of the memories I carry, those recalling days before my creation are somewhat unclear. Furthermore, the haste that I must necessarily employ ensures certain inaccuracies in the form of summary. And if the end-times sun undoes the magic that made me or bakes my limbs into useless branches, you should know that it is the same kilny sun whose light I count on to envitrify my words into the soft clay before the salt-laden tides of the last sea smother them out.

The story begins in Jewish Harlem, before the southern blacks replaced the Jews and before the Hispanic immigrants replaced the blacks...

* * *

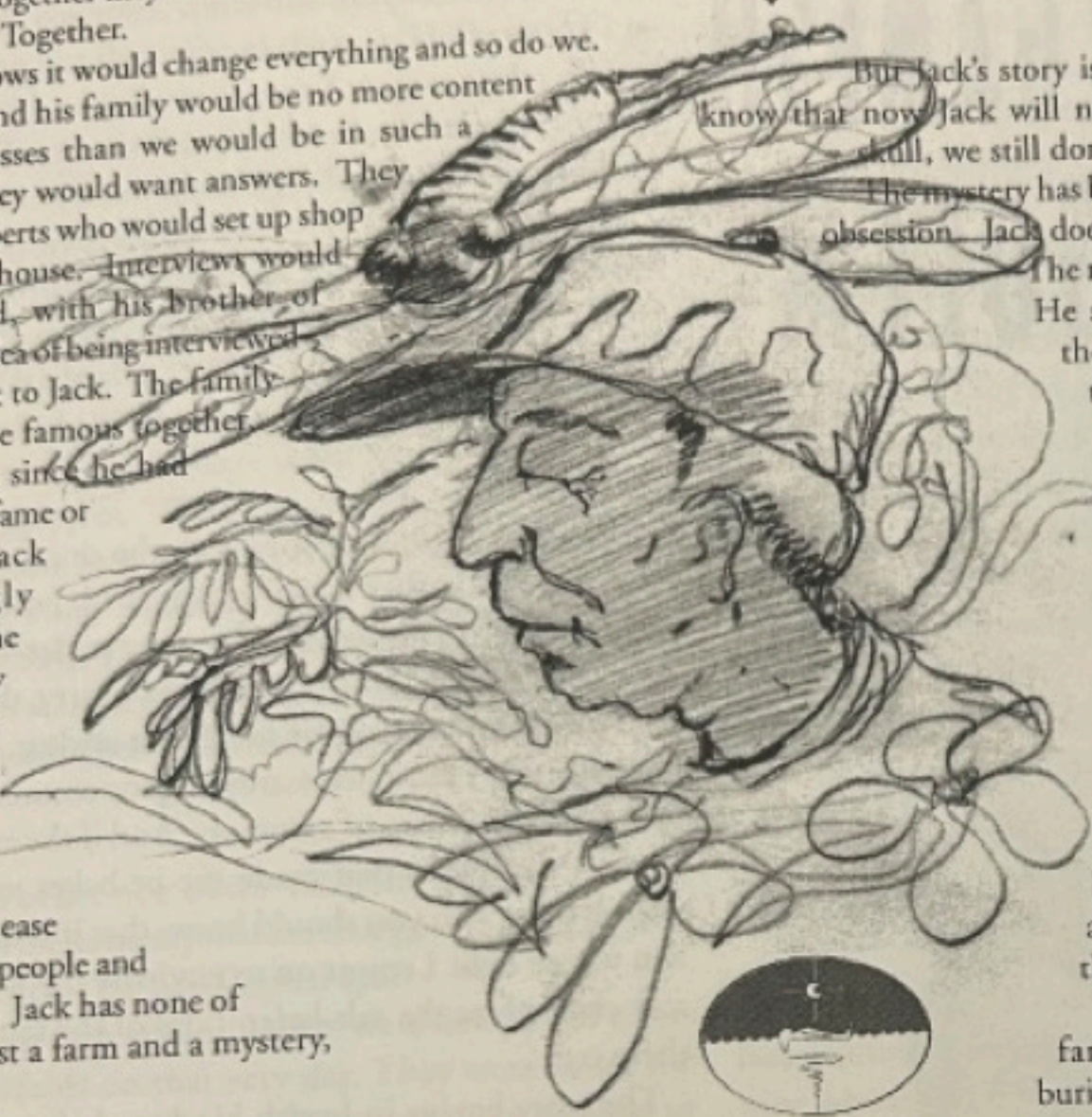
Paul's mother was displeased in the extreme when she found out that her money was coming from boxing. She had stopped taking the blood money, as she called it, when word got around the neighborhood that Paul "The Maul" Stein had ended a fight by clocking one of the Italian boys and blinding him in one eye. Consequently, Paul and his fiancée had a modest savings.

They had planned to get married in grand fashion, possibly even in their own semi-luxurious apartment whose neo-Egyptian façade was shaded during the hottest part of the afternoon by the shadow of the new Empire State building, where Holly worked as an assistant executive secretary. It was the nature of their respective professions that they spent most of the day apart. Their only contact was at dinnertime, after

the bond between two brothers than by exploring the mystery together. Jack would take his brother to the giant skull, looming fourteen feet high amid dogwoods and crabgrass, and then together they would bring his sister-in-law and niece and nephew, and together they would talk about the skull and guess at its origins. Together.

But Jack knows it would change everything and so do we. His brother and his family would be no more content with idle guesses than we would be in such a situation. They would want answers. They would call experts who would set up shop in Jack's farmhouse. Interviews would be conducted, with his brother of course. The idea of being interviewed was abhorrent to Jack. The family would become famous together, without him, since he had no interest in fame or fortune. Jack begrudgingly admits that he is already jealous of his brother, his beautiful wife and wonderful children, his ease around other people and his quick wit. Jack has none of these gifts, just a farm and a mystery, his mystery.

This brother and his family are outside Jack and his giant skull, so much so that we need not even name them. He smiles and mutters simply, "It's nothing." His brother shrugs, shakes Jack's hand, and leaves.



But Jack's story is not quite over yet. Though we know that now Jack will never tell anyone about the giant skull, we still don't know what he will do about it. The mystery has become an obsession, a very private obsession. Jack doesn't like it.

The next two weeks are difficult for Jack. He stops going to the skull at night, though he still sleeps little. During the days, he repaints the barn, then begins packing. He makes a trip into the small town of Waynesville and withdraws all his savings, then makes arrangements with a realtor. He tunes up his pickup truck. Finally, he goes back to work in the field. Using the tractor he drags the skull back to the vast pit he unearthed it from. He unhooks it, and with his own strong hands he pushes the thing back into its tomb. He spends the afternoon filling the hole up, closing the mystery for good.

In the morning Jack is gone, the farmhouse is empty, the mystery is buried again.

-7-

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reasons and answers, and if they are not readily available, questions become obsessions.

When the planting is done he turns his attention to the old farmhouse he inherited from his father. Dust collects in amazing quantities in all the nooks and corners of old farmhouses, and

Jack spends an entire week cleaning it from top to bottom—washing windows, scrubbing floors, packing away winter clothes and unpacking summer clothes, dusting and sweeping and dusting again, cleaning the tops of cabinets and the bottoms of shelves, and cleaning under everything. At night the dreams creep in, dreams filled with lumbering shadows, palaces in the clouds, deep booming voices that rumble the very earth, and vague towering figures as tall as the ancient redwoods.

During the days, Jack's mind works harder than his body. He tries to think about anything but the skull sitting in his field. His mind is busy while patching shingles, repairing steps, hammering creaky floorboards, and tightening bolts on loose shutters. He thinks about his brother and sister-in-law and their children; they will come to visit him in just a few weeks, when school is finished for the year. This is always a fun time, if awkward. He loves his niece and nephew, he is able to be himself around them without fear of judgement or of saying the wrong thing. He has more difficulty being around his brother and his sister-in-law. Adults are always difficult, and those you are closest to can be the most difficult to understand and communicate with.

He thinks about the old house. He supposes that over the years he and his father before him must have replaced everything in the house at least once, and he wonders if it is the same house it was when it was first built, over a hundred years ago. He wonders about identity—is it in your bones?

He is on a ladder on the west end of the farmhouse, repainting it. This is a job that needs done every year, since the winter winds come from the west and buffet this side of the house with rain and ice. He likens the coat of paint he is putting on to skin on the bones of the house. And then he is thinking about the skull again, wondering about its massive presence. Where did it come from? How can such a thing exist in a world of concrete rocks and fields and trees? He chews on these questions for a long time, and can find no reasonable answers, no explanations. When he finally stops he climbs down from the ladder and steps back. Jack gasps and falls to his knees. On the north wall of his barn, he has painted a huge white skull.

That night, though exhausted, Jack cannot sleep. He tosses and turns, trying to shake the questions out of his own skull. Finally he climbs out of bed, dresses, and leaves the farmhouse. He walks slowly across the backyard, across his fields, and into the small grove of trees where the skull sits silent and undisturbed. Moonlight shines down on this clearing, lighting the shadowy eyesockets. Jack is in awe. He drops to his knees in front of the impossibly large skull and just stares. He sits here until the dawn comes.

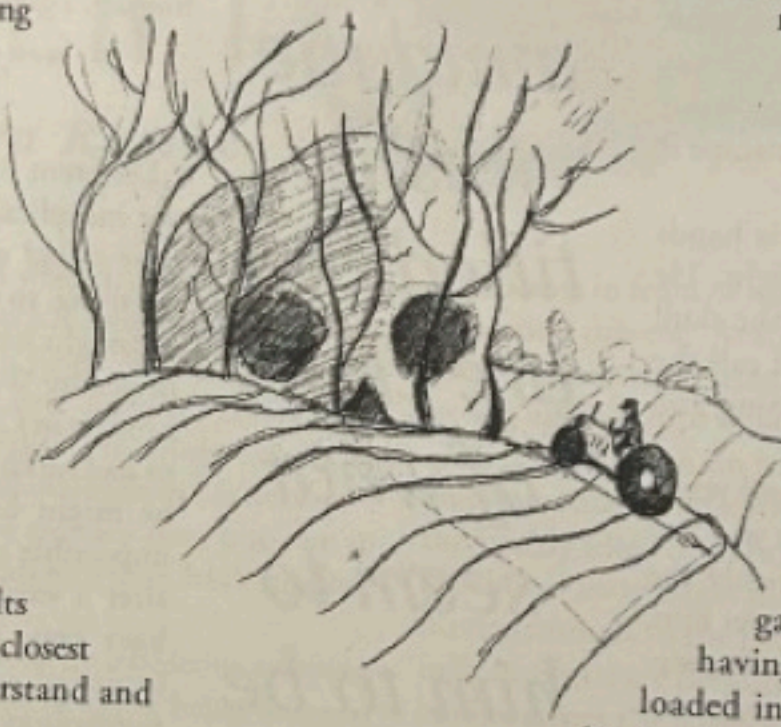
Three weeks later his family comes and visits for the weekend. This is usually Jack's favorite time of the year, but now he is exhausted. Jack has slept little in this time. He has given up cleaning and repairing, choosing instead to spend his days in a lawnchair staring at the skull, making sketches or even talking to the thing at times.

He spends little time playing with his niece and nephew, he is even more withdrawn than normal. Throughout the weekend, his brother tries time and again to draw Jack out of his shell, asking his opinions in conversations between himself and his wife, or suggesting that Jack might like to play baseball in the backyard with the kids. Jack mostly shrugs or nods or answers questions with a single word. Jack hears them whispering at night about the skull painted on the barn. By Sunday morning it is apparent that the children are bored, anxious to return home to cable television and video games, when usually they are sullen at having to leave at all. After everything is loaded in the car, children and wife included, his brother takes him aside.

"I know you're not the talkative type, but it's pretty apparent that something is weighing heavy on you, man." Jack is silent and chews his bottom lip thoughtfully. "If you're in some kind of trouble, financially or otherwise, we're glad to do whatever we can to help, even if it's just being ears to listen."

It occurs to Jack that he wants to tell his brother about the skull, more than anything he wants to unburden himself of the weight of this obsession, and he knows there is no other adult in the world he would be more comfortable talking to than his own brother. He briefly recalls moments of their childhood together, gathering locust shells from trees, making tents from sheets in their bedroom, exploring the woods south of the farmhouse, and chasing lightning bugs. These were shared times requiring little speech between brothers, and Jack values the memories.

What do we want Jack to do at this point? There is a deep longing within us to encourage Jack to open up and share this with his brother. This mystery of the giant skull is too heavy for one person alone to bear, and what greater way to strengthen



Christians. Our suppositions would be incorrect though; Jack is uncomfortable in the presence of any people, preferring the silence of his bean fields, or at most the gurgling voice of his tractor. He sits down in the dirt, crosses his legs and takes a deep breath. He closes his eyes and feels history wash over him. This sensation is much like the calming, elemental feeling he has when letting his fingertips explore the boulders he has unearthed, but it is both more powerful and subtle. His breathing slows and his broad shoulders relax.

Though he would never admit to doing such a thing, Jack is meditating. His mind, wandering through its own back alleys and earthy tunnels, imagines a prehistoric world shaped by the storybooks he sometimes reads to his niece and nephew. This landscape is filled with lush foliage, towering palm trees, and the rich smells of old forest and fresh decaying leaves. Three-foot long dragonflies buzz through the hot air and the harmonic rise and fall of locusts fills the shadows. In the distance a great roar sounds and an alligator-like lizard lurches out of a bush and into a murky pool of water covered in giant water lilies. His dreamscape is rendered in vivid Crayola colors.

After some time Jack withdraws his hands and opens his eyes, blinking in the sunlight. He returns to work, putting thoughts of the skull out of his mind. He supposes he will call the local community college in the morning and speak to an archeologist.

His dreams that night are vague, and when the morning sun pierces his bedroom window the next morning, he awakens with only the memory of towering shadows looming over him. He drinks a strong cup of coffee to wash away the night and sits down with the phonebook, thumbing through it until he finds the phone number for the college. He picks up the telephone receiver and then pauses. His mental image of the thing in his field has faded over night and now he wonders if perhaps he was mistaken. Perhaps it was in fact just a large slab of some light and flaky sedimentary rock. He drops the receiver back in its cradle and gathers supplies for a lunch, then goes to the barn.

He drives his old pickup truck out to the field, a shovel and a mattock in the bed, and when he stops and examines the discovery again, he is quite sure it is bone. He does not spend time in meditation again; his mind is on work and that is what he sets about. He starts with the shovel, clearing off the top layer of dirt, being careful not to damage the surface of the skull. Then he moves out several feet and goes to work with the mattock, tearing up clods of dirt and digging a trench around the thing, nearly twenty feet in diameter. In a few hours he is drenched in sweat despite the brisk March breeze.

When he stops for lunch he does not look closely at what he is unearthing. We might be curious to look at it, see how far we

have progressed, look at its shape and touch it again and again. Jack prefers to save that pleasure until he is done.

He returns to the mattock and the shovel, letting his muscles and tendons stretch across the arc of the afternoon. His thoughts are quiet and he becomes absorbed in his work, not stopping until the sun reaches the horizon. He takes a long drink of water, splashes some on his face and neck, and finally looks down to examine the thing he is unearthing.

Jack was certain, just a few hours into his digging that day, that the thing was indeed a skull of some sort. But until now he had not looked at it directly. Now he stares at it, takes in its proportions, its overall shape, the placement of the eyesockets on the front of the skull, just above the nasal cavity, the bulbous top and back, the high cheekbones and brow ridge. He now realizes that it is certainly too large to house a tiny dinosaur brain, and shaped wrong to be a dinosaur or a mastodon. This is the skull of a human, a giant human.

*Scattered
amid the
freshly
tilled dirt
are chips
of what
seem to
him to be
bone...*

Different people deal with the mysterious and the inexplicable in different ways. Jack might have called everyone he knew to come look at the thing, to try to make sense out of it with him. He might have called his old high school friends in nearby Waynesville, he might have called his brother in Cincinnati. Had his father been alive or had he known the whereabouts of his mother, he might have called them to come see this impossible monument unearthed from his field after a week of careful excavation. He might have gone to the library, spent untold hours hunched over dusty books of folklore and mythology, thumbing through archaeology journals and textbooks. He might have called up the community college, summoning an expert to explain the inexplicable, who in his bafflement

would summon his colleagues from other schools or digs, turning Jack's field into a major archaeological find, changing the face of science as we know it.

Instead he tries to forget about it. He uses the muscle of his tractor to drag the skull into the corner of a field, amid a copse of dogwoods and bushes. He goes about his planting, working sixteen to twenty hours a day to catch up for the week lost in the excavation. At night he sleeps the dreamless sleep of the dead. And for a while, he is successful. The overwhelming exhaustion in his body and the focus on work in his mind are enough to keep thoughts of the giant skull at bay.

Thinking is dangerous for Jack, although he doesn't know it. The decision not to think about the skull was not an active one, he just thrust himself into his work and stopped thinking for a while. He has no explanation for the giant skull, he has not thought about one. He has not realized that the human mind doesn't deal well with mysteries. The human mind needs

A BURIED MYSTERY

Shannon Rampe



4 It is a rather brisk spring afternoon when Jack first encounters the giant skull. He sits perched atop his coughing John Deere Tractor and squints across the barren fields. Behind him, rows of blades turn the earth, making it new again for the crop of soybeans to be planted in a few weeks. He thinks quietly to himself, carrying along a slow careful dialogue in his head.

The life of a bachelor farmer is a solitary one, but one to which our hero, should we deign to call him that, has long since adjusted.

Jack's afternoon reverie is interrupted by a hideous scraping from behind him, much like the sound of a fork being dragged across a chalkboard. He mashes the brake and the clutch and yanks the trundling machine out of gear. He climbs down from the tractor and steps past the plough blades, peering at the careful furrows of earth between his dirty boots.

Jack, though mostly uneducated, has always been a quick thinker and had taken a bit of interest in geology in high school. Even before he begins his examination, he is making educated guesses as to what the source of the sound was. He knows that tens of thousands of years ago this countryside was covered in mile-high mountains of ice. When the mountains finally withdrew from their explorations of these more southern lands to their ancient arctic haunts, they left behind souvenirs brought from the north: boulders. The endless workers wind and rain often buried these beasts. Other times they seemed to bob to the surface, as if their rich history made them too buoyant to hide long in the earth's crust. This had happened in years past, and now Jack felt a familiar excitement set in.

Jack has a great love of rocks and stones, identifying with their silence, their strength, and their solitude. He respects their long lasting endurance. He has unearthed other boulders in other years, the largest weighing nearly three tons. They now

sit in a row in front of his old farmhouse, suggesting eccentricity to passing drivers. At times, Jack takes comfort in running his hands across the pitted surface of these ancient behemoths, letting his fingertips walk across a history older than humankind.

He squats down on his knees and pushes the furrows aside, and immediately he notices something strange. Scattered amid the freshly tilled dirt are chips of what seem to him to be bone. He shoves away larger piles of dirt and exposes a large off-white hump, smooth to the touch and nearly three feet across. At six inch intervals are parallel grooves where the tractor dragged its blades across the surface.

Jack stands up, brushes off his dirty hands on denim coveralls, lifts a Red Sox baseball cap, and runs his fingers through his thinning blonde hair. What is a farmer to make of this? What is anyone to make of this, much less a man who has spent his life in so simple a way as farming, his greatest surprises coming from the turbulent and often unexpected Ohio weather? We might stereotype him as a typical redneck, supposing he thinks first of UFO's, underground missile silos, prehistoric Atlantaeen ruins, or secret government conspiracies. But he is no more typical than ourselves or anyone else, and he supposes he may have discovered the skull of a dinosaur or a mastodon. He read just last week in the paper about a farmer in Auglaize County who uncovered the remains of a mastodon. How odd then that this is something far stranger, far more inexplicable than mammoth skulls or secret government conspiracies. If he were more inclined to fancy, would Jack be more or less surprised when he finds out the truth we already know?

Jack is not a religious man. It isn't that he does not believe in God, rather he just does not care or think about the topic. Given his next action, one might suppose that he would feel more comfortable in the company of Wiccans than that of

Holly had spent a long day in the office without a break and Paul was readying himself for the evening's fight. Sometimes, the famished couple would go back to Harlem where Yiddish and Italian and Irish voices filled the air with the restless spirits of the old countries, voices that complemented Mother Stein's cooking like the spices of the east. Holly would impress them with anecdotes of rich foreigners who always seemed to make extraordinary demands of the secretaries or, on lucky days, to bestow upon them ludicrously large tips in exchange for everyday kindness.

It was on one such occasion that Paul first heard the name Israel ben Muhammad. Holly normally paid scant attention to changes of leadership in the company, but the buy-out by an Arabian oil baron precipitated an especially large shake-up among the employees. "The stars portend opportunity," Mrs. Stein told her son knowingly. Indeed, Holly ended up filling her own supervisor's newly-vacant position as lead executive secretary, handling the appointment books of ben Muhammad himself.

She learned of her new boss's real estate aspirations on the same day that the change in management for the East Central apartment buildings took effect. Notices were first posted to inform the residents on that very day. They were on all the walls, and in all the mailboxes. They were given by hand to every occupant, sometimes more than once. The postings shrouded the fine sheeny wallpaper with a quiltwork of mottled parchment.

In order to keep the "criminal element" at bay—some anti-Arab graffitiism had taken place in the otherwise immaculate children's daytime care facility—all residents were asked to carry punch cards. In addition, for reasons that were poorly explained, rent would be upped for certain occupants. Paul and Holly would have to pay more than triple the normal due.

The old landlord's chair and desk were replaced with a velveteen paisley dos-à-dos, and a new door had been cut, presumably into the adjoining suite. Paul defiantly pounded on the door, though he knew he wasn't even supposed to be in this office-cum-foyer. "Hey Mac, that area is off limits now," one of the janitors had explained to Paul, whose punch card was already scuffed and bent from being tried in all the newly-locked doors that metamorphosed the building into the impregnable Egyptian tomb its lotus trumeaux had al-

ways bragged it was. The janitor had diffused Paul's evident rage when he punched his own card, as payback he said, for the five bucks he'd won off last week's fight. "I wouldn't mind if you gave that new landlord a good right hook anyways, Slugger." But here he was, pounding on the door instead of the landlord.

A scratchy electric voice, like those at the larger boxing arenas warned that unappointed queries may result in fees or even termination of the lease, and Paul argued with it momentarily about the appropriateness of his visit until he slipped the note under the door. The rent envelope came on the 28th of every month, and this one had contained instructions on how to contact the landlord for a lease review. Why the lease needed reviewing was second among Paul's concerns, which were dominated by the draconian restrictions on his options for an appointment: "Anytime after 4pm on a business day before this month's rent is due."

"Mr. ben Muhammad will see you now."

The suite was air-conditioned—a luxury even for such a fine apartment building. The secretary directed Paul around the corner to the landlord's relaxation chamber. The conversation did not go well. Paul

spoke, facing away from the landlord, who lounged in a freestanding washbasin, smoking from a long meerschaum pipe whose smoke did a better job keeping away the flies than the peacock plume he switched them with. Ben Muhammad sat quietly until Paul had exhausted his lexis in a blubbering plea that touched on the wedding, elderly parents, and the potential for injuries in his line of work.

"Please have a seat in the foyer while I consider your case, Mr. Stein."

Paul did as he was asked to, but he found himself scratching the extravagant gold leafwork from one of the dos-à-dos's arms. The repetitive motion calmed him.

"You will be billed for defacing the furniture." The secretary's voice itched over the loudspeaker. "This fiancée you mentioned; she lives with you here, does she? In that case, we will have to relocate one of you to the nearest vacant apartment until after the wedding. You will, of course continue to pay the increased rates. If you are unwilling to comply with the rules of this building, you are encouraged move into any of the other East Central buildings, some of which retain independent management. That will be all, Mr. Stein."

"Excuse me?"

*"The stars
portend
opportunity,"
Mrs. Stein
told her son
knowingly.*

cold Atlantic with Holly—or the mindless body that bore that name—sitting comfortably on my chest.

* * *

As I write this, the waves of the Atlantic are still crashing on gently sloping shores, though the shoreline has receded and the ocean has been split into two strings of slushy salt puddles running along either side of a vast mountain range.

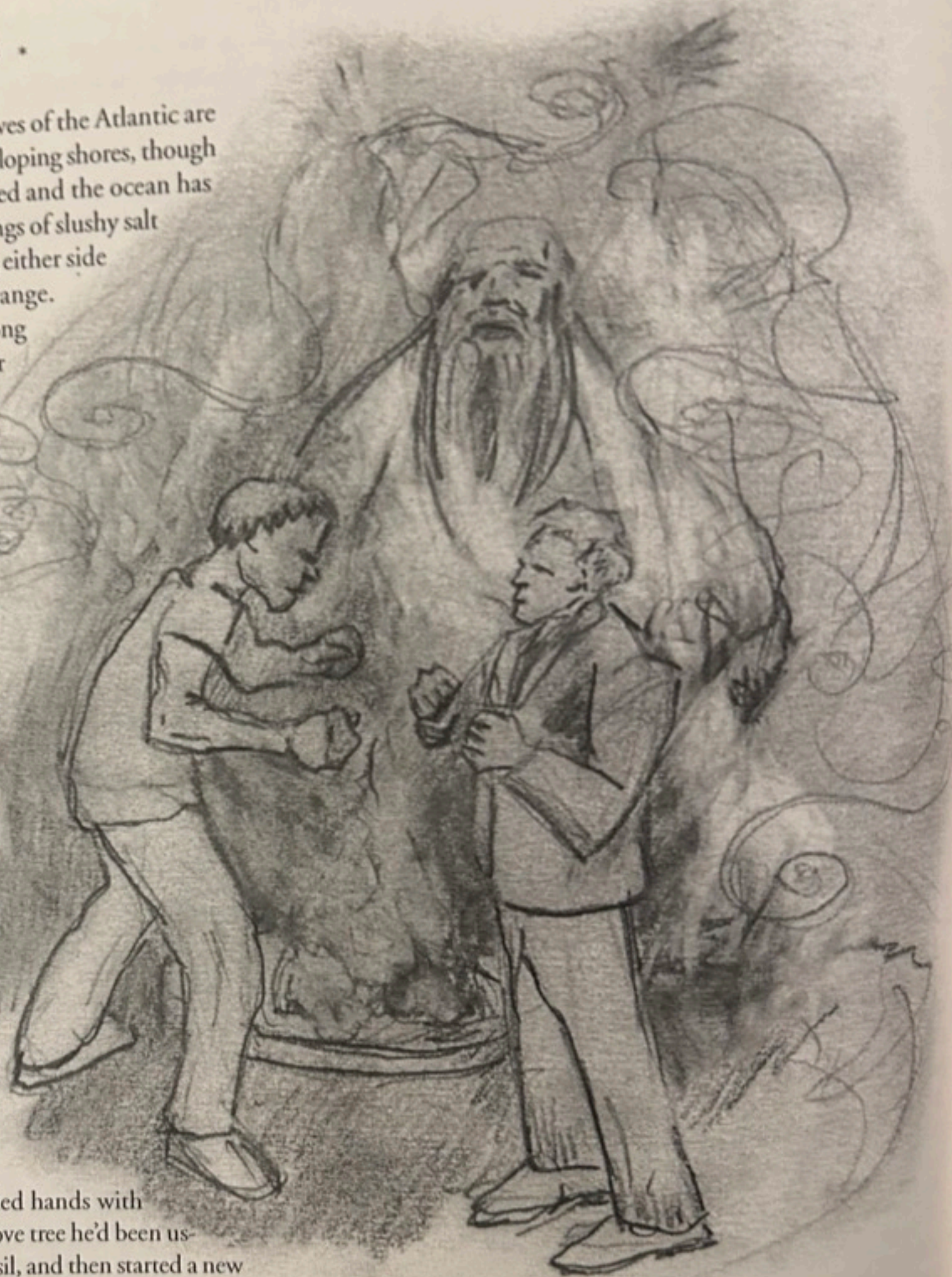
New York city is now long gone, as are the ever changing peoples of that ghetto called Harlem. When the sun has expanded and scorched me

to a frozen statue, you may find my body on the peak of a mountain that was once an island.

-14- There, I will be lying alongside a pile of ashes that were once the bones of my dear Holly. But before I retreat into my private eternity, I must complete my tale...

* * *

The golem switched hands with the petrified mangrove tree he'd been using as a writing utensil, and then started a new column of inscription. "In glory to the Prophet (blessings be upon him), I write this tale in a sincere attempt to inform the reader—should there be a reader—of the true history of my creation, if it is Allah's will that I finish before the end times sun undoes the magic that made me or bakes my limbs into useless branches..."



tate." The rabbi tore down the curtains and cloaked his new body with them, leaving the apartment through the still-open doorway.

Paul tried to stand, but he had no control over his—the golem's—left leg. "Damn it," he said out of the right side of his mouth. "You damned idiot. If it wasn't for your greed, I'd have my wife and you'd have your riches." He began punching the left side of his face, chipping greenware knuckles and cheek. The left arm tried to do the same to the right side, and they struggled until both eyes cried in tearless despair.

Eventually, the left side of the golem's mouth said, "Stop it! Stop it, Mr. Stein."

The left arm flung itself limply to its side, and the right continued to work at destroying them both, pounding deep cracks in the hand and wrist, neck and face.

"I really do love her."

"You don't know what love is," said Paul. He took a breath and

put the hand to his forehead, feeling dust and bits of clay slough off underneath his fingers.

He pounded until his caly muscles ached, then the golem sat solemnly in front of the smokeless fire.

"Help me. All I want is to hold my Holly again, even under these circumstances," said the right side of the Golem.

"What can I do? Robbed of my body and rendered in clay, what good can I be?" asked the left.

"I don't know. I can't think. I can't do anything; I can't even cry," said the right.

"Can this god of yours help?" asked the left.

Paul considered this for a moment. God wasn't supposed to be part of his vocabulary. He was a man of the flesh; a man of the fist.

"Of course," Paul started to lean forward with the right side of the golem's body, and ben Muhammad followed his lead with the left. The fire rose at the movement.

"Yahweh, help us. Give Holly her free will back."

"I have made a covenant to give each of you command over the girl's will. I cannot breach that covenant."

"Then, please give us back our bodies."

"As I said, I cannot contravene a covenant once made. Only Rabbi Samson can give you back your bodies. Perhaps I can help you in some other way."

"If you can't restore our souls, what can you do for us?"

"I must do whatever you command that is within my power."

"Then give this body the strength to overcome Rabbi

Samson, Yahweh," said ben Muhammad.

The flames grew, and with them the golem's body. Over the fire, the golem took on a vitreous sheen. The surface became covered with glass scales, and the bulk continued to expand. Soon, the ceiling bowed against the golem's shoulders, then it broke and debris fell from the upper levels of the apartment building into the basement. The fire consumed it all, and the golem had to step away to keep from hardening into bisque. As the golem grew greater and greater, the partition grew thinner and thinner, stretching imperceptibly between the two souls.

* * *

*"Enjoy your prison,
children..."*

It was in that fire that my story begins. Though the rabbi had divided me in two, I had to work as one being. Oftentimes, I wish I had continued to grow and grow until my body formed a world

unto itself. Alas, that was not to be.

I was compelled towards the pinnacle where my lover would be opening a safe full of money on an upper floor. I stumbled and fell along the way, rending ironwork and bits of pavement under my weight. By this time, my feet were the size of a trolley cars and my stride, the length of a city block. I walked to where the shadow of the Empire State Building pierced the daylight on the street. People fled in terror before me, but by then I didn't care. My cares were torn between love and hate briefly, when I saw the tiny rabbi scurry into one of the East Central apartment buildings. I ignored him, and grasped at the Empire State building with an enormous hand, breaking windows and bending steel. I climbed until I could look with my left eye into the office where Holly removed money from the safe without emotion or haste.

"Holly," my voice was hoarse and inhuman, but she responded anyway. "Come here."

I wrapped one arm around the side of the building, so I could lift the other and give Holly somewhere to stand. She obeyed, climbing out the window into my giant clay hand. As she did so, the building started tipping and screeching. I stepped down in time to back away and watch it fall like a tree, with tiny people diving hopelessly from the windows. The collapse obliterated all of the East Central apartment buildings in one long, billowing crunch. The city was alive with sirens going every which way, and maybe no one noticed when I took a deep breath and did a backstroke into the

ing a cold draft to douse candles and to bear scrolls off tables. Uncut Samson was taken by surprise, nude, piggish, and shaking when Paul grabbed him by the arm, sinking strong fingers into the flab. A sucker punch to the face was stopped when Paul felt a paralyzing blow to his own spine.

"Stay out of this. I'm going to kill him for ruining my bride."

Paul turned on ben Muhammad and they began a dirty wrestling match. But, their battle was not yet to be. The fleshy slap of each strike quieted to nothing while the apartment filled with thick incense smoke until both men collapsed in a desperate embrace. They awoke lashed together and suspended over a smokeless fire and immediately began to struggle against each other, against the ropes, and against the flame.

"I will pay you," ben Muhammad yelled in between curses, "Holly, go get the money in my safe." Paul stopped slamming his skull against the other man's in time to see her run out the open door. It left both men relieved enough to stop struggling.

"If you think I want Miss Landis's body, you're mistaken. Soon, I'll have the body to take the women I wasn't strong enough to take in this body. I'm glad you both showed up here, but it's a pity that a golem fit for a wizard has to be wasted." He swung a lumpy arm towards an unrealistically muscular clay sculpture of ben Muhammad. "It took a long time to find a body sturdy enough to suit my tastes." He stroked the arm of the sculpture, and snickered. "You should be thankful. This magnificent creature is beyond value. It was fashioned in 1654 by Dutch Jews, fleeing the Portuguese in South America. They offered it to the Governor of New Amsterdam to protect the city from the Swedes, but instead he arrested the Jews and put the golem up for auction. It sat in a Brooklyn root cellar for three hundred years until I found it. Soon, you will fulfill the purpose of watching over this city—my city—at my bidding. You will inhabit a body with quite a pedigree. Personally, I'd rather have the real thing." Samson's cheeks reddened and he approached the men, gazing away from their eyes. "When I have your body Mr. Stein, I'll be strong but I'll still be human. And when I have your face, Mr. ben Muhammad, I will control your wealth. How much are you worth? Millions? Billions?"

Samson began chanting in a tongue neither of the men would have recognized by name. He bent himself and fanned

the flames with his hands as he alternated between prayer and silence in cyclic rhythms. On one cycle, he looked up and addressed the two men. "Have you ever heard the tale of Gilgamesh, who would split a baby in half so that two fighting women could share motherhood?"

"Isn't that the story of Solomon?" said ben Muhammad. "Shut up." The corners of Samson's mouth turned slightly upward and his eyes widened. "I told you each that you would have sole power over this woman, and I never rescind a promise."

"Don't kill her, please," said Paul

Samson waited for the end of the chant to reply. "Idiots, you think I would kill your girl? You two can continue your fight over her as long as you like, for all it matters to me. Killing is a sin."

The rising flames drew Paul's eyes. He could see that they were hanging above a burning bush. "Lord God," he screamed, "please help me!"

Rabbi Samson laughed. "Yahweh," he addressed the bush by God's ancient name.

"What do you require of me, great Samson?"

"Give me the wealth of the oil baron and the strength of the boxer."

"Shall I cast their souls into hell?"

"No," he said even as his body was being reshaped, "ensoul the golem doubly."

As he spoke, the fat seemed to melt from Rabbi Samson's body, and his skin seemed to darken, become more youthful. Paul had trouble focusing on the rabbi. The scene was a jumble of images, and he could see his own body from the outside, writhing in exact complement to ben Muhammad's. He could see both bodies starting to dissolve into a wisp of smoke over the burning bush. Soon, the rabbi's body stopped its distortion. Paul tried to move stiff limbs, but they felt clunky and he seemed undecided about which way to move. His emotions too were a jumble. They were still filled with hate for Samson and love for Holly, and hate for ben Muhammad. But there was self-loathing as well. Ben Muhammad was present inside him.

"Yahweh, partition the golem." With the rabbi's words, the chaotic admixture of souls ended in pain. A line burned down the center of the clay form, singeing both souls and demarking a boundary that kept ben Muhammad in the left and Paul in the right.

"Enjoy your prison, children. I'm off to dabble in real es-

*They
awoke
lashed to-
gether and
suspended
over a
smokeless
fire...*

was afraid ben Muhammad was holding his fiancée against her will.

"There's a fellow might be able to help you. He's a rabbi."

Paul's mother was shocked. "Rabbi Samson's only a rabbi in title. The man is a lush. Don't you go near him." It turned out that Samson was a lascivious whoremonger who was rumored to masturbate at the talkie theaters. "Uncut Samson," they called him. He was, however, also a renowned mystic and that's what made up Paul's mind. Nobody doubted the Rabbi's powers.

After a particularly bloody match, Paul delivered himself to a gas-torch lit doorway that stood below street level only two blocks from his mother's apartment building. The door had a bronze plate inscribed with Hebrew letters, though with the streaked green corrosion and Paul's limited knowledge of Yiddish, he could only tell that it said something like "All are welcome."

Samson was a fat and greasy slob whose once-exquisite accommodations had been used beyond their capability, and now exuded a pungent fetor that seemed to waft out of holes in the carpeting. The rabbi glanced at Paul senior's clothing and said, "You can't afford my prices." Paul told him that there was plenty of money in the ring for anyone tough enough to claim it. Samson laughed at the implied threat, but waved him inside anyway.

"I know of Israel ben Muhammad. He's obsessed with himself, like most of the world's better men. Your fiancée would be well off to stay with him rather than a low-born boxer from the

ghetto." Samson left him alone long enough for him to reconsider his decision, but before Paul's mind could make

sense of these awful circumstances, the rabbi emerged from behind a curtain-wall. "It is done. The girl will be yours. Now give me whatever money you have and go away."

Paul didn't know what to expect, if anything, but he couldn't stand to waste time in actionless wondering, so he walked as fast as he could to the apartment building whose neo-Egyptian façade dripped silver rain like mercury in the bright moonlight. Holly was there, waiting in the alley. She was silent. Paul tried to talk to her, but she seemed not to know him. She didn't respond at all unless she was asked a direct question or given a command.

"Are you okay?"

"Yes."

"What's happened to you?"

"I don't know."

He told Holly she would have to come with him, but she followed at a snail's pace, and when he carried her, he wasn't able to move much faster.

The walk back to Harlem ended as the sun was rising over Mrs. Stein's apartment. Though he collapsed with exhaustion in his mother's spare bedroom, his mind was restless with angry confusion. Holly lay open-eyed next to him, and when Paul finally gave up the fight to keep his eyes closed, she accompanied him arm-in-arm through the foggy morning street.

The rabbi's door appeared to be stout, but it only took one solid blow to unhinge it completely, allow-

*Paul bloodied
the artist's
nose and lips,
dropped him
and boxed his
ears; he would
have killed the
man...*



"One moment Mr. Stein... Mr. ben Mohammad says that he will be claiming your fiancée as well."

"What?"

"Mr. Stein," it was ben Muhammad's voice this time. "Because of the problems you've caused here today, your tenancy has been terminated. The lease will be transferred to the name of Miss Landis. She will stay here with me, where you may trust that she will be in good hands."

"Just who in hell do you think you are?"

"Sir, please try to understand. She is mine. Since before you were born, I've dwelt on that face. I realize you love her, but I loved her first. You see, when my father brought me to New York as a boy, the beauty of American women astounded me. But there was one in particular. Her name was Honey. The wife of Milt Landis, her face caused my heart to weep. It was the memory of that face which I followed back to your country. Now, I've seen that face again, and it is Holly, the daughter of Milt and Honey Landis. She will be my bride. Please leave the premises now. Do not attempt to reenter your apartment."

-10- "That will be all Mr. Stein," concluded the secretary.

On the way out, Paul regretted not provoking the guards who stood by to see that he boarded the elevator to the lobby. As he stepped out the front door, a voice sounded from above.

"Hey, you're the sparrer. Pauler the Mauler, right?" An overalled man squatted on the top rung of a ladder, holding a pile of gold foil in one hand, and a jar of glue with a paintbrush jutting from it in the other. He spoke with a Scottish accent. "Do you live here?"

"Not anymore."

"Too bad. I suppose you don't like the management? Well, a lot of folks round here feel that way. I can't say as I share the opinion, though. If it weren't for Mr. Mohammed, I wouldn't have a job. My family and me flew all the way from Edinburgh, and Mr. ben Muhammad paid for the Zeppelin tickets. He says he's going to make these apartments into a utopia. I feel like I'm working for the pharaoh himself."

Paul threw his body against the ladder, and picked up the little man by the collar. Several onlookers fled, but one of them—the janitor from upstairs—swung a fist at the air.

Paul bloodied the artist's nose and lips, dropped him and boxed his ears; he would have killed the man if he hadn't

seen the Tommie-gun-wielding guards appear. As he left the chaotic scene, he looked over his shoulder and the janitor shouted out. "Way to go slugger," he said, only to be beaten and dragged off by a gang of security guards.

Another guard hollered, "Cut him off, he's heading across the street."

Paul and Holly were supposed to meet at the foot of the Empire State Building, but there was little chance ben Muhammad would allow that to happen, so instead he hopped a jittery trolley into Jewish Harlem. Ghetto faces

lined with cracks stared at Paul, like ancient pottery sitting alongside a museum reproduction designed to imitate the beauty of newness. Mrs. Stein's tenement was infested with age, from the ladies with pepper pot figures to the tall-hatted Hassidic men who discussed philosophy over chess. Even the Irish boys who played stickball out front seemed oddly wise for their age. Paul had grown up here, but he felt he had pampered away his street wisdom. He no longer belonged.

"What should I do, mom?"

"Stay here with me. Holly will know where to find you."

It took Paul a few days to realize that his mother was wrong. He had taken out his anger in the boxing ring. He told his mother of the Micks and Negroes he had beaten, no doubt winning his fans more than a few dollars. He didn't men-

tion the Jewish boxer that would never again be able to bite into a fresh apple with his own teeth because of Paul's callused fists. One night, Paul went back to the apartment building dressed in his late father's ragged work clothes. Paul and Holly's apartment was on the seventh floor, and he could barely make out shapes moving in yellow light. He stared for nearly half an hour before he saw Holly looking out the window. He shouted up to her, but she didn't seem to hear.

"Paul the Maul! You don't look so good, slugger."

The janitor had a huge can of garbage that he dragged towards the alley. He said that ben Muhammad had allowed him to keep his job after he had promised not to talk to a single person while on duty. In the quiet of the alley, they talked about Holly's coming and going and the increase in modern conveniences, and the accompanying increase of security at the building. The whole place was air conditioned now, and the elevators were automated, but many of the tenants had been evicted to make room for newcomers who could afford the forbidding rent. Paul told the janitor that he

*"I
wouldn't
mind if
you gave
that new
landlord a
good right
hook..."*

"No, I don't know Thomas," I say.

"He'll be back soon. He gave me this," she says resting her hand on her wheelchair, "and that television. He's a good kid."

I walk out of the room, marveling at how Mrs. Dawson has declined since the last time I spoke with her. I walk down the hallway and hear the woman on the television scream "No!" and break down into a fit of crying.

I walk outside and past my bike and wagon to the garage. I raise the door and there isn't a sedan anywhere. There are boxes filled with clothes. Some are filled with cookware and newspapers. There's a blue upholstered couch and chair, too. But no sedan.

A white and blue object thrashes in the treetops as I ride back to my mother. I stop peddling and coast to the side of the road. I get off the bike and skulk toward the object hanging in the trees.

It's a parachute flapping about seventy yards from my bike. I have to keep swatting away gnats to get a good look at it. I begin to climb the tree until I hear moaning about ten yards away. There is a man wearing blue jeans and a navy button-up flannel shirt laying face down on the ground. A gray pack with two lengths of rope extending from it, both with frayed ends, is fastened to his back. He moans through dried blood on his lips and chin. I feel his body. His legs and some ribs are broken. I don't know how long he has been lying there. I reach in his back pocket and pull out his wallet. There's a picture of him and three women, probably his wife and two daughters. His driver's license indicates that he's Henry David Wright and is thirty-three years old. I grip my hands under his arms to see if there are any breaks in his bones. They are all right so I drag Henry out of the woods to my bike.

My lower back aches. He is still breathing but I don't know if he will make it to my bike. He probably weighs about one hundred and seventy-five pounds, about eighteen more than me. When I get to my bike, Henry is unconscious.

I heave him into my wagon and throw the bike off the side of the road, and then I pull the wagon back to my mother's house.

It's dark when I get home and fireflies flash in the fields. I push the front door open and drag Henry inside by his arms. I rest him by the door and check his pulse. It's weak. I leave him there momentarily and walk into the kitchen where my mother sits at the table with her back to me. I don't know if she notices I'm home or if she even expects me back. She has a shoebox of photographs next to her and is crying under the dim kitchen light.

"Mom," I say, concerned.

She doesn't say anything and grabs another picture from the shoebox.

"Mom," I say again.

She sniffles and says, "I know how to treat a man, Jackie. I really do."

I step back to the front door and grab Henry by the arms and drag him past the opening to the kitchen and into the bathroom. I start filling the tub with cold water then I prop Henry in it. I go back to the kitchen.

My mother must've heard me come in. She says, "I was good to your father, Jackie. I know how to treat a man."

"Mom," I say.

"I really do," she says.

"Damn it, Mom," I yell, "listen to me."

She stands up and slaps me about as hard as she can. It sends me to my knees. Tears surface in my eyes and at that moment I want to be the man in the bathtub, the one so close to death.

"Don't you cuss at me," she says standing over me. "Don't you ever treat me that way."

She pauses for a moment, breathing heavily and crying. "Where are the groceries?" she asks.

I can't form words in my dry throat. She stands over me and wails and then goes toward the

bathroom.

"And you leave the water on," she says, "You waste water?"

I step outside as she walks into the bathroom. My chest hurts. My back hurts. My face stings. I try to compose myself while staring at the flashing lights of fireflies surrounding me.

*What she
doesn't know is
that I saw my
father flirting
with a senior
soccer player
shortly before
his departure.*



and bolts, rusted buckets of paint, and a tool box, all covered with strands of spider web that have crisp, lifeless insects strung through it like Christmas lights.

I empty the wagon and cuss at the damned spider webs as I disentangle myself from them. I pile everything against the wall and pull the rickety wagon to the old banana seat bike, the wagon's wheels squeaking along the way.

I ride the bike down our dirt driveway while pulling the wagon until its wheels lock crooked and I can't correct it and the thing falls over by the mailbox. I get off the bike and kick the wagon, leaving a dent in its side. I cuss and pace. My mother stares at me from the front window. I don't know how much she's witnessed. I wonder if she feels like she has any part of my tantrum, if she feels like she provoked it. I turn the wagon upright and pedal hard to get away.

My crotch is soaked in sweat and my wet underwear is chaffs my leg, the beginning of a rash. Beside me is empty country, fields of prairie grass that have lost their pigment, a light-yellow mess of dying fields. On the other side of the gravel road is a stretch of woods. I stare off into the openness of the sky, my eyes probing the horizons, while I pedal to the rhythm of the squeaking wagon.

When I pull up Mrs. Dawson's drive, I notice there isn't any corn set out for the ducks at her little pond. There are usually mounds of it. Only a few ducks remain. They float on the surface of the pond and dip their heads down, scavenging for some food at the bottom. I pull the wagon up to the rotted, gray fence parallel to Mrs. Dawson's front walkway. My legs are weak and throbbing.



I ring Mrs. Dawson's doorbell four times. No answer. I check the knob and it's unlocked. There's a foul smell inside. I hear a man and a woman arguing in the back of the house.

*I saw him,
morning and
night, standing
on the slanted
floor of our
small kitchen
in front of the
sink, drinking
glass after
glass of discol-
ored water...*

I walk down a hallway lined with paintings of parrots and into a small living room. There's a birdcage with its door, but no sign of any bird in the house except for some feathers on the floor. I see Mrs. Dawson's white head of hair tilting to the side of a wheelchair she sits in. The chair has a control panel on the right arm that looks motorized. In front of Mrs.

Dawson, a man and woman fight on her color T.V. I call Mrs. Dawson's name but she doesn't answer. I call again, louder, but still no answer. The woman on the television cries and tells man with his back to her she loves him. Mrs. Dawson's mouth is agape and her skin is almost an olive color. Her chest slowly expands. I nudge her cheek a few times with my hand. She opens her eyes and grabs this large hearing aid off a T.V. tray beside her.

"Is Thomas here?" she asks. Her body convulses when she speaks. Her voice is small and coarse, as if she has laryngitis.

"It's me, Jack," I say. She clenches her lips together tightly and leans her head forward. She raises a shaking hand covered with a few dark liver spots to her right ear.

"Do you remember me?" I ask. "I'm your neighbor, Jack," I say, raising my voice.

"Where's my Thomas?"

"Who's Thomas?" I ask.

She reaches to the T.V. tray again and grabs a framed picture. In it is a woman wearing a red dress next to a man in a Navy uniform, and between them, lower in the picture, is a young man who looks to be in his twenties wearing a plaid shirt. I'd guess the picture is pretty old. She points to the boy in the plaid shirt. He looks like a younger version of the man I saw in her car with her around Christmas.

"He's so handsome," she says.

On the television, the man starts walking away from the woman but she grabs his shoulder and turns him around. She cries and tells him she loves him, again, like it's the only thing she can say to make him stay with her.

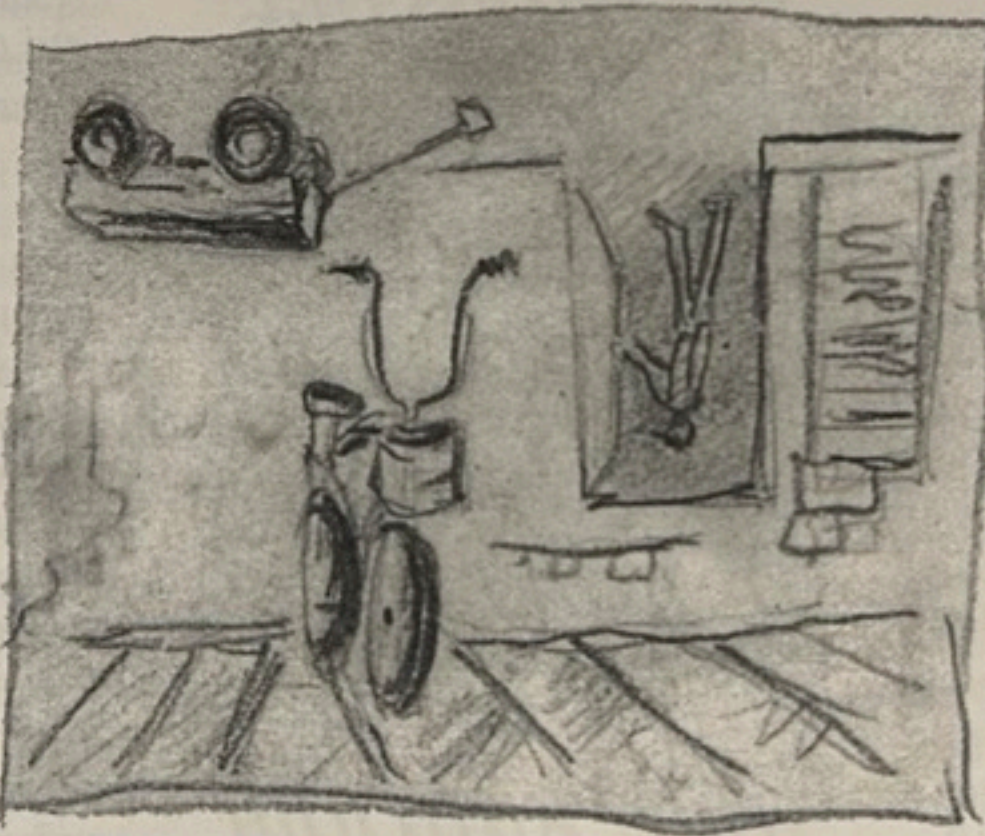
"Can I use your car? I need to run to the grocery for my mother," I say.

"Is Thomas with you?" she asks.

For a moment, my mother stares at me, her lips quivering. Her clogged lungs whistle. She says, "Mrs. Dawson will let you use her car. You thank her for it. You make sure Solomon gets this list. He'll take care of us. You do that for me." Then she places the bowl of corn in the fridge and retreats back down the dark hallway into her bedroom and shuts the door. Her coughing is faint. I look out the window and hope that a distant bird is really a plane searching for survivors.

I strap the envelope against my back with the waist of my jeans. The air outside is humid and drains a salty mist out of the pores of my forehead. There are gnats caught in the sweat on my forehead. There are patches of woods scattered around the section line road where I live, and, during the summer, all kinds of foreign insects swarm around my flesh, crawling into my hot mouth. I lift the door open to the garage and stare at the oil

stains on the floor, which no longer have any real substance to them since my mother's leaking Honda is missing. Hanging from hooks on the ceiling is the green bicycle with a flower-patterned banana seat and a wire basket extending from the white, rubber-gripped handlebars. No one will see me on the bike. I wish it were a viable concern. I'm concerned about the haul, three miles down the road to Mrs. Dawson's. Not only do I have to drag a wagon behind me with one hand steadying the bike on a dusty gravel road, but also my transport is a relic older than I am and it doesn't have gears. There isn't a means of control to make the ride somewhat tolerable. On the way back I'll have to drag a wagon full of groceries, mostly canned products. It doesn't make sense to me. I could just drive Mrs. Dawson's car over to our house, empty the groceries, and drive it back. But my mother insists I don't waist any more gas than what's necessary. So I'm stuck with the wagon. I reach up and push the bike out of the hooks, balance it, then try to ease it gently to the oil-stained floor. I push the bike to the front of the garage and lean it against the frame of the garage door. Then I go over to the other side of the garage and clear out the wagon. It's filled with jars of nails



She grabs the bag of peas off of her neck and slams it against the counter. She comes up to me and yanks the bowl out of my hands and puts that, too, on the counter. She pauses and takes another long, deep wheezing breath. Her eyes are wrinkled and her skin looks thick and dark from years of smoking. Her jowl quivers. "God damn it, Jack," she says and puts her fingers to her temples, "we can't be wasting food. You put that corn in the fridge and finish it later."

My mother has bursts like this. Something remains unsent in her. Five years ago, my father left us with little money. He went out west to Las Vegas, said he was going to work for a big casino. My mother tells me he was following his dream. She thinks it's easier for me that way. But her fits of depression and madness forced me drop out of school. I did what I could to help her. But it takes so much out of you sacrificing my time, whoever I was supposed to be then. I

I read brought her cigarettes and read her the newspaper. I endured her dusty novels from the library and fed her. I endured her recollections of the good days she had with my father. She cried and said it's good he has ambitions and does what he wants to. But I know she felt an unrequited love for a man that didn't want what turned out to be his life. She told me many times she tried to be a good wife and she loved him. When my father left for Vegas, she needed someone to take care of her. I was fifteen and it was like I had to prepare drips for an IV that she guided around like a lost child.

What she doesn't know is I saw my father flirting with a senior soccer player shortly before he left. She had brown eyes and long, curly blonde hair that everyone in school wanted to smell. I dreamed about her during my geometry class. Most likely, my father wasn't alone when he passed through the gateway to the West or stumbling along the pulsing Vegas streets. In weaker moments, I'm the mistake, conceived on some drunken night. I'm the reason the marriage ever happened, the reason it lasted as long as it did. I'm a fluke in birth control, a faulty condom.

"Oh, oh . . . and make sure you get a couple cartons of cigarettes for us," she says, pretending to pull off of an invisible cigarette.

"It's almost seven months since I've seen her," I say looking up from the soggy corn, and I think about her saying "for us" like cigarettes are a family expense, even though I don't smoke directly. But I breathe in her smoke that fogs the family room when we watch fuzzy game shows, the waves of static crackle on our black and white television. Yet another artifact wrapped in foil. Thus we receive three scrambled stations.

But the television is missing. So my mother hasn't had much to do but rummage through every closet, shelf and drawer, to remove the clutter. This morning it's the fridge she scavenges, ignoring everything I say.

"Why don't you just call her first?" I ask. "At least I won't startle her that way."

-16- "And we're going to need a lot of canned food. Vegetables, pasta, fruit," she says. She stands up and puts her hand on her forehead like she's checking for a fever, then takes a deep wheezing breath and her head disappears again behind the freezer door.

"Call her. Call Mrs. Dawson, Mom," I say as I stir the corn bits.

She pops her head up from behind the door to the freezer again. "Honey, the phones are dead. Silly. Had you forgotten?" She seems tense, a smoker without cigarettes, and I wonder if maybe she has her head in the freezer to cool off.

I did forget, for one reason or another, about the storm that uprooted trees over and filled our yard with puddles. This was a day ago, early morning. Sometimes it's hard not to feel like I've been forgotten, left alone on a deserted island, scanning the horizon for search planes.

I'm nineteen years old but can't prove it. I drive but don't have a license. The only identification I have is a library card to a library that burnt down more than a year ago. The news said it had something to do with skinheads. Anyway, I couldn't use the library much toward the end of its days. We live twenty-six miles from town and I didn't drive often. My late fees made things hard and they wouldn't let me check out any more books.



*I see small
purple veins
forking in
different
directions
like little
rivulets on
her plump,
pale legs.*



"The storm, Honey. The phone lines are still down," my mother says and grabs a bag of frozen peas out of the freezer. She bangs it against the countertop to loosen them and drapes it around her neck. She leans over the countertop and scribbles down some more items on an envelope.

My mother says her car is broken and in the shop being repaired. It's been there for weeks, in a small town shop where business is slow. I assume she's sold it. That and the television, too. Or, she does have money, enough for groceries, and it's inside the sealed envelope addressed to Solomon she's writing the grocery list on. Right there, one the table. Solomon is a large black man, bulky like a bear. He's bald and has a manicured beard. He also has this giant's chest with hairs that curl and spread down to his paunch. I saw it heaving out of his robe, morning and night, standing on the slanted floor of our small kitchen in front of the sink, drinking glass after glass of discolored water in these huge Hawaiian shorts. Then he'd disappear back into my mother's bedroom and close the door.

We didn't talk much. Maybe during those silent moments in the kitchen we shared a greater understanding of why we didn't want to wake my mother and we kept quiet to ensure we didn't. He was friendly when he was around. He said "Hello" and asked me how things were and other mindless conversations like that. I didn't mind the guy, really. He seemed to make my mother happy, on some level anyway. And he kept gas in the car and brought home groceries from his store in town. And I am supposed to go get groceries from him. Yet I haven't seen him since we had a car and a television.

"I didn't hear the storm. Was it bad? Did it hit town hard?" I ask, resting my elbows on the table. I'm done with the corn.

She rolls her head in a semi-circle, trying to loosen up her neck. "Well, you can see the debris in the yard. You know, it was kind of bad, I guess," she says.

I pick up my bowl and head for the sink with it and ask, "What about in town? Solomon tell you anything about damage in town?"





-15-

The Nature of Fireflies

Ben Crites

I don't hear about the small charter plane that crashes into the woods two miles south of us until two days later. I imagine the lights of the plane disappearing behind thick clouds, the engines sputtering out over a field swarmed with fireflies.

My mother asks me to ride her old banana seat bike four miles up the gravel road to see if our neighbor, Mrs. Dawson, will lend us her sedan. We need groceries.

"What if she's dead?" I ask my mother with my head tilted down, shoveling up cold corn out of a bowl.

She pokes around in the fridge, her slip showing. It lifts when she bends down to take stock of the spoiled vegetables

and fruit in the drawers. I see small purple veins forking like little rivulets on her plump legs.

"We've got a lot of peanut butter, maybe we should get some celery. That'd make a good snack, you think?" she asks.

"When did you see Mrs. Dawson last?" I ask.

She pulls out a clear plastic bag with blue lettering. In it are long stalks of celery browned with age. She piles it on the mound of trash, mostly consisting of old foods – jars of spoiled pasta sauce and mayonnaise, rank sandwich meat, things entombed in Saran wrap and foil.

"Last time I saw her was Christmas," I say.

A half hour later, I enter the house with dry eyes. My mother is talking in the bathroom. She says she knows how to take care of a man, over and over again. I step into the hallway and peek into the cracked opening of the bathroom door. My mother is sits on the edge of the bathtub, still crying. She's delirious. "I know how to treat a man," she sobs. She wipes a rag against Henry's forehead. He's dead.

She stands up and pulls her shirt off. "See," she says. Her skin is pale and I see the sides of her sagging breasts. Then she pulls down her jeans and her white cotton underwear. She stands naked in front of the dead pilot.

"See," she says.

I turn away and walk into the kitchen. I pull out the letter to Solomon from my waistline. I'm about to open it when lights flood into the kitchen. I look out the window and there's my mother's Honda with Solomon turning off the lights and walking toward the front door, the car still running. I put the letter in the shoebox.

-20-



I meet Solomon at the front door before he can knock. "Hey, Jack, what's going on buddy?"

"Nothing," I say.

"Hey, did you hear about that plane crash from the other day? You know, when we had that big storm," he says.

"No," I say. "I don't know what happened to the television," I say, looking at him sternly.

"Oh," he says. "Hey, is your mother around?"

"Nope, she's gone."

"Good. Do you mind if I come in and look around? I think I left my watch here. You know, it has leather straps."

I stare off behind him at my mother's Honda. I watch a firefly light up then disappear. I stand there for a moment and wait for it to reappear, but it doesn't.

"Come on in," I say, still looking for that firefly to light up a. "I think I saw it in the bathroom," I say and let him in. Then I walk outside, get into the car, turn on the lights, and disappear.



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HUNTING

-

BOATING

-

FISHING

-

CAMPING

Family owned and operated.

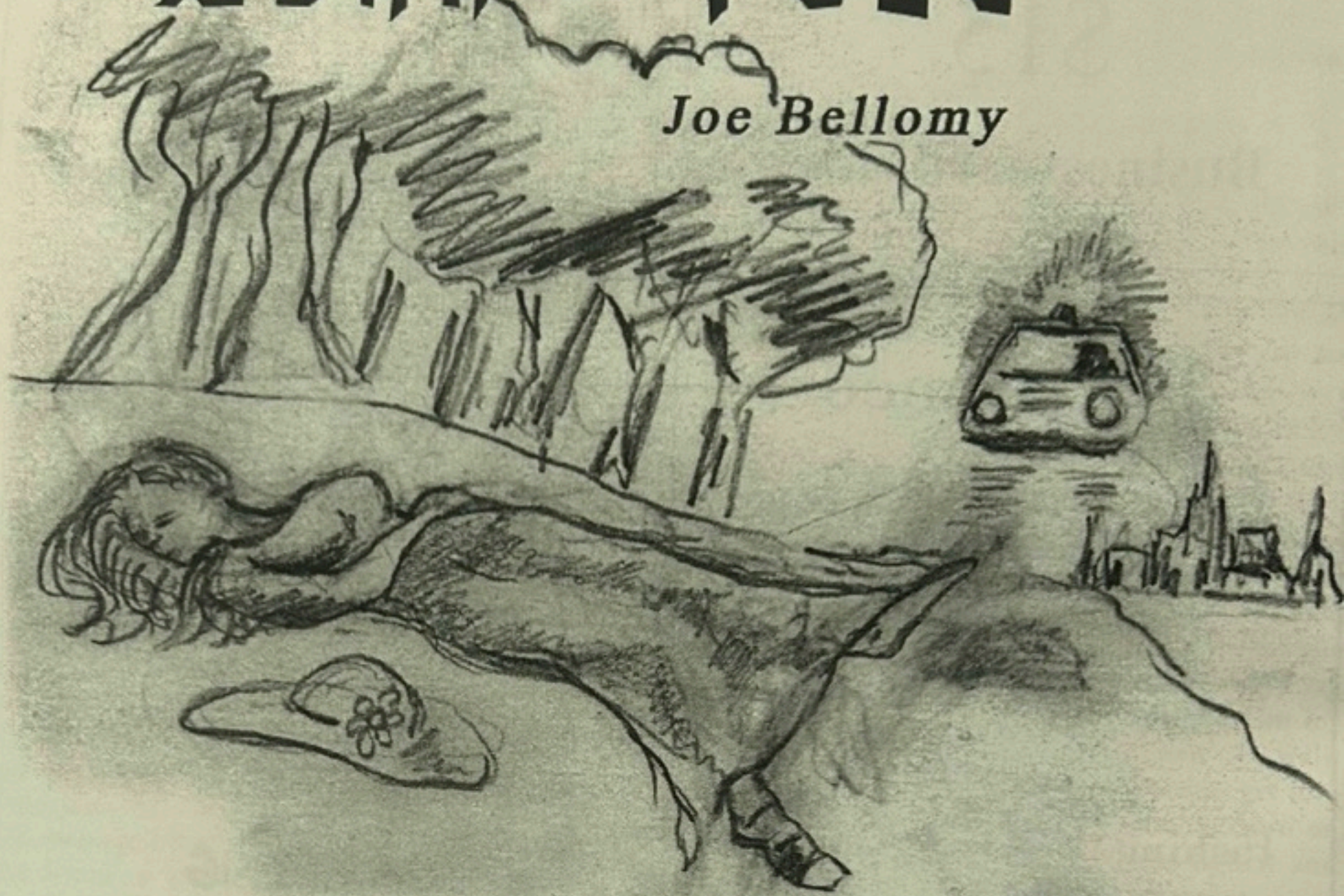
Burt's Meat House

Serving Savory Simulations

519 Whitney St.

WORK and PLAY

Joe Bellomy



-22-

The only thing Glenn Shaw didn't like about his job was the sensor implanted just below his right jaw line. On the other hand, he figured, for the kind of money he made, they could put a sensor up his butt.

He scratched his neck. Damn thing always acted up when rain was threatening. Larry Guccio, Glenn's supervisor, didn't seem to be bothered by his implant. Feet propped up, head back, he looked like a corpse, indistinguishable really, except for the heavy snoring. Glenn felt like kicking his chair and waking him up just to have someone to talk to. Instead, he began to doodle on his monitor.

Wednesdays were slow at the center. For some reason members didn't play much on Wednesdays. Swing shift hadn't had a run all night so midshift probably wouldn't either.

Bored with his drawing, Glenn cleared the screen and punched up the technical manual for the Sekimine fiber maintenance unit.

FIB MAINT; SEC 4A...VOL II... TRAC 2... D 675
SEKIMINE FIB MAINT UNITS 4, 6, 8.
ENSURE AREA IS CLEAN

Place section to be restituted near victim in approximate position of normal configuration.

Enter victim's BIO CODE at control pane. Place entire victim in Sekimine regenerator models 4, 6, or 8.

(Note: Models 5 and 7 operate manually, reference Trac 677 for appropriate operating procedures.)

Secure hatch. Timing priority is automatically programmed.

DO NOT OPEN HATCH.
ENSURE AREA IS CLEAN

Love always,
Daisy

* * *

Glenn leaned back in his chair at the Blue Hat. He was a little nervous. He had checked Ringo Baker's file at the center and had found a monster.

In the profile photo had been a man of forty-two, two hundred and five pounds of what seemed solid muscle with the expression of an extremely intelligent bull.

Daisy was picking at her apple pie. Glenn watched for a few minutes as she flicked off the top crust with her fork.

He did love her, he thought. She was just so full of life and joy. Everything for her was an event as if she were constantly walking across an opening-night stage, basking in some invisible spotlight. He wanted to please her so badly he was ready to face anything, even her beast of a husband.

He had been watching the entrance continually since they arrived, but even with his vigilance, he was surprised when Ringo entered. The big man wore a black leather jacket and a serious expression. He didn't hesitate in the least, but scanned the dining room and headed directly for them when he spotted their table. He sat down, leaned over, and brushed his lips across Daisy's cheek. Daisy scooted uncomfortably away from him.

"We don't want any trouble," Glenn began.

"You already got it son."

"Now, wait a minute. We just want to talk. Get this out on the table."

Daisy's eyes were wide. She followed the conversation intently.

"Look Mr. Baker. Daisy and I are in love and..."

"I'll just say this once, son. You better just get up and walk out that door."

"I'm not afraid of you," Glenn said, trying to sound as confident as possible, trying to keep the quaver out of his voice. "We've been seeing each other for a month now..."

"So that's how it is?" Ringo spat at Daisy.

Daisy nodded quickly.

"One more chance," Ringo said, leaning menacingly over the table. "There's the door."

That was it. Glenn could tell there would be no conversa-

tion here. He took Daisy's hand and stood up. "Fine then, we'll just be going." He nearly pulled Daisy out of her seat and through the dining room towards the door. He sighed deeply as they left the building, thankful that confrontation was over.

Ringo watched them go. The woman was just too much, he thought. He waited only a few moments then got up and followed.

Just as they reached the parking lot, Daisy dropped her purse. She stooped and began stuffing her things back inside.

"Come on, Daisy," Glenn said nervously, looking toward the exit of the restaurant. Frustrated, he bent to help her.

As if from nowhere, Ringo appeared. He pulled Daisy to her feet. "All right girl. That's enough of this. We're leaving before things get out of hand."

Daisy broke away from him, ducked behind Glenn. He could feel her hands tight around his arm. Ringo was pretty

big, Glen thought, feeling the adrenaline rush into his system, preparing him for action.

"I love him!" Daisy shouted over his shoulder.

Glenn touched her hand reassuringly, then gave Ringo a steely eyed glare, one that forewarned his pending attack. That's when Ringo punched him in the head. Glenn collapsed like a wet rag. He woke with Daisy patting his cheek and Ringo trying to pull her away.

Glenn shook his head clear and struggled to his feet. As he got his footing, Ringo punched him in the stomach knocking him back to his knees.

"You still love him?" Ringo shouted.

"Yes, yes," Daisy answered. "Get up Glenn! Fight him!"

Glenn got up...then went back down from another blow to the head.

"You still love him?"

"Yes, yes!"

"Damn you, Daisy," Ringo fumed, his voice was low and cruel.

"Please, Ringo. It's fun."

Glenn got to his knees and Ringo pulled him up the rest of the way.

"Do it," Daisy said breathlessly.

Glenn struck out wildly. His fist caught Ringo in the face.

"Come on! Come on! Fight! Fight!" Daisy was jumping up and down and clapping her hands. Her hat fell off her head and thin wisps of her blonde hair stuck to her flushed lips as

joe bellomy

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Work and Play

frigid."

"And you actually enjoyed it?"

"Sure!"

"No...um...I mean, being a victim."

"Oh. No, not really."

"Then why are you doing it now?"

"I told you, my husband Ringo likes it." Daisy finished her burger and drank down the last of her beer. A feminine burp surprised her and she smiled coyly. "What time is it?"

"About six now."

"Oh! I better get going! Ringo will be wondering where I've been." she stood, breasts jiggling. The attendant looked up.

"Wait a minute," Glen said. "I know this is stupid, but, could I see you again?"

She smiled. "It's about time you asked."

Glenn and the attendant watched her leave with equal interest.

Ringo L. Baker was daydreaming in his office. He was worried about his wife. She seemed to be restless lately. It had been only a month since he had last killed her. She couldn't want to play again so soon, he thought. Perhaps she was getting bored with the game. Daisy got bored quickly.

Maybe it's you she's bored with.

Ringo shook his head at the thought, but it persisted.

You're getting old...and Daisy...she's young and beautiful. She needs excitement. Wasn't that the reason you joined the Game Center in the first place? For the excitement?

Ringo looked around his office. He had everything one could want: money, status, respect...a lovely wife. Then why was he so depressed?

He shook his head again, tried to pull himself out of the mood. Ringo L. Baker had not gotten where he was by feeling sorry for himself.

He tightened his jaw, his thick eyebrows converged. He had to admit it to himself. He thought Daisy was screwing around on him. That was the source of his anxiety. The question was: What could he do about it?

The crowd was thick, but Glenn spotted her large floppy hat easily. The plastic daisy clung desperately to its brim as she squirmed her way through the mass of people. It had been nearly a month since he and Daisy had begun seeing one another. Each time their meetings became more and

more secretive. Her husband was getting suspicious. The crowd rolled around them as they met and embraced. "Where have you been?" she whimpered against his shoulder.

"Right here, sweetheart." he answered, kissing her lightly. She pushed him away. "Please, I'm upset."

"What is it?"

The crowd squeezed out a fat woman and pressed her up against the two lovers, so close that Glenn could feel her flesh undulate with the motion of the mob. The woman braced her legs and her frown against the tide of people and began to dig into her purse.

Daisy began to cry. "I think Ringo suspects something."

"So?"

"You don't understand. He's cold and mean, Glenn. He'll come after you if he finds out."

"Calm down," Glenn said. "Maybe it would be better if he did find out. Maybe we should come right out in

the open with this thing. We're not fooling anyone, you know."

The fat woman snapped her purse shut, raised her chin, and sailed away.

Daisy turned her head up, lips just touching Glenn's. "Maybe you're right. Maybe it would be best. I'll...I'll tell him tonight."

Glenn took her in his arms then, kissed her hard. "No matter what happens," he said. "I'll always love you."

Their kiss ended with a pop. Daisy smiled. "Let's go get a burger.."

* * *

The first thing Ringo Baker found upon entering his home was a note Daisy left on the kitchen table. He read it carefully, set it down, then picked it up and read it again.

Dearest Ringo,

I care for you so very very much and would never want to hurt you too badly. But I've met someone new and we're in love and he thinks we should bring this out into the open. So, if you want to talk about it, meet me at the Blue Hat at eight tonight.

Glenn went to his room. He felt weak and drained from the night's work. The gray morning light cut through his window and pressed against the floor. He sat down in his magno rocker. Feet dangling, chair gently swaying in the air, he began to think about moving out.

After he finished this latest job, he'd have enough credits for a down payment on an apartment—just a down payment. Then he'd have to find someone to split the rent with him.

There was Sadie...but Glenn didn't know if he could handle living with her. She was a pop tab collector, seven thousand could win you a free trip to Las Vegas or a weeks worth of shopping at any participating mall. Sadie was the kind of girl who always kept her head down looking for discarded tabs on the street.

But she did have a nice body and she wasn't too particular about loaning it out. With his hands behind his head, Glenn began to consider the idea a bit more. What he really needed was a woman like this Daisy Baker he had picked up earlier. A woman like that might put him into high gear, make him take some kind of definitive action in his life.

Back in the living room his mother pushed the red button.

"Oh!" Daisy said as Glenn helped her down from the regenerator rack. Holding her elbow, he walked her across the room to the recovery couch.

"How do you feel?" he asked.

"A little dizzy," she said. "But that will pass. It always does." She looked him up and down. "Are you new here?"

"Been here three weeks now."

"What happened to Roger?"

"Roger?"

"The other guy who worked here," Daisy said. "He kind of gave me preferential treatment."

"I...uh...guess he quit. He wasn't here when I started."

She was even more beautiful alive, Glenn thought.

"Are you hungry?" he asked, thinking: Rule number three—victims are always hungry after being rejuvenated.

"Starved!"

"How about a burger?"

"Ghads. You eat that crap?"

"Well..."

"I know this wonderful little French restaurant just east of the park. It serves the best food." She looked around suddenly.

"Where's my purse?"

"It wasn't around when I picked you up. I found your hat though."

Glenn went across the room and got it for her. "Look," he said. "I've only got a few credits and anyway, it's four in the morning, I doubt if that place would be open. So, how about a burger?"

Daisy took her hat and popped it on her head. "Guess I don't have much choice since you're buying," she smiled.

At four in the morning Burt's Meat House had only one customer...and he was ordering to-go. The attendant, who had been slouching over the service counter, perked up as Daisy walked through the door. He sneered at Glenn, but gave Daisy a goofy, yellow-toothed smile.

They ordered two Burt Beanburgers, two nutrapops, and two sides of soyfries. The attendant took their orders grudgingly, then watched Daisy's behind as she and Glenn found themselves a table.

"So, what do you play?" Daisy asked as they slid into the booth.

"I don't play anything. I work."

"Oh, I haven't tried that yet. Maybe next year."

The attendant shuffled over with their burgers. He crooked his neck as he tried to get a glimpse down Daisy's low cut dress. She frowned and he slinked off.

Her eyes are so blue, thought Glenn. He found himself swooning a bit.

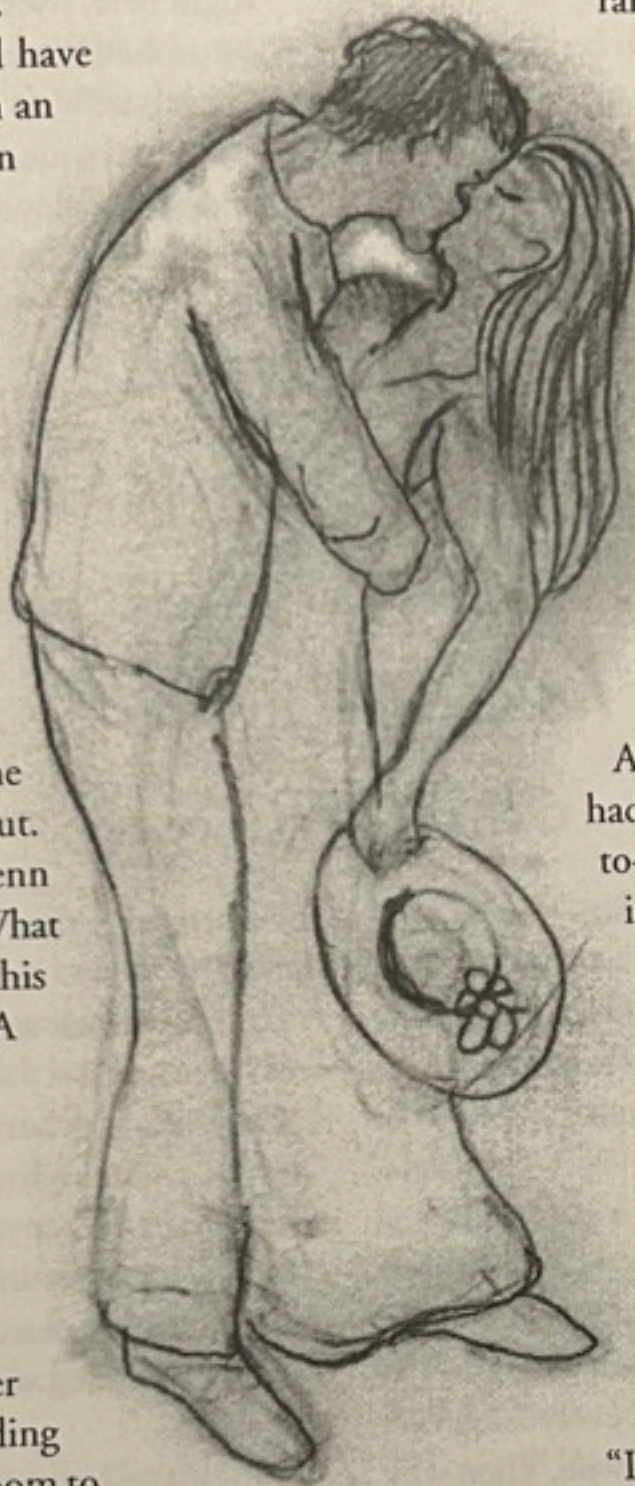
Daisy took a bite from her burger and wiped a drop of mayonnaise from her lower lip.

"How did you get involved with the Center?" Glenn asked.

"My husband. He likes the games."

"Do you?"

"I don't know," she said, shrugging and bouncing her head from side to side. "I've always been a victim. Even in school. I was always getting picked on. In sex-ed they called me



joe bellomy

kill kit. The park was quiet except for the thunder that rumbled in the distance. He glanced at his watch. She'd been dead five minutes, plenty of time for the section monitor to respond. He should be there any minute. Ringo felt a little uncomfortable about leaving his wife alone and dead in the park. There was no telling what kind of perverts wandered around this time of night.

He sighed. That was part of the game though. Murderers don't stick around after a killing to make sure no one screws with the body.

It had been a long chase and Ringo was tired and winded. She had led him on a wild chase clear through the wooded commons before he had been able to tackle her on the bike path. He picked up his wife's purse and found that she had enough credits for him to buy a few drinks—drinks he sorely needed. The game was beginning to bother him. He'd never really liked it at all. But Daisy insisted they play, and as always, Ringo did what Daisy wanted. He took the credits and the purse then walked slowly away into the darkness.

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* * *

She was lovely, and she'd been strangled.

Her skin was a cool ivory in the street lights. She lay crumpled on the pavement, the clinging satin dress flowing around the soft curves of her body. Her eyes, wide open and glazed, were bluer than the cursor of his monitor screen. A wide brimmed sun hat lay near her, a plastic daisy sewn to its side.

Glenn opened the back of the van, pulled out a spirit bag and the portable compressor. He wrapped her in the bag, sealed it, and attached the vacuum hose. Within seconds the bag had shrunk to conform to every rise and fall of her body. Soon he had her in the van and was gliding down Salisbury toward Whitney.

"Radio on," Glenn said.

"Bob," came the announcer's smooth voice. "How about giving us the latest news."

"Well," said Bob, "It's been an interesting day. Some of the usual winners have lost and some of the usual losers have won. The Bullets really took a beating today, losing by seventeen points to the Eagles. Charles Dandy lost his left hand during the first quarter of the play, but was back in the

second to avenge the death of his teammate, Rick Harrison. In San..."

"Channel," Glenn murmured.

"...Perhaps, perhaps not, but nevertheless, Moon Lincoln lost the lead at the very finish of the Houston finals and..."

"Channel."

*"What do
you do if you
can't find a
part of the
victim? Say...
his leg is
missing?"*

"And the winner for this evening is number 0799987-00a." Glenn listened until the news programming ended and the station returned to regular programming. A heavy beat began and a sad voice wailed.

Losers and lovers

How many can there be

Losers and lovers

That's all that I can see.

As the tune drummed on, the van drifted through the center's security shield and floated into its parking spot.

"Did you get her into the oven all right?"

Larry asked as Glenn entered the control room.

"No problem. She'll be as good as new by tomorrow night."

Larry turned back to his console and typed in Daisy Baker's personal data.

Baker, Daisy J.

Female

Blu, Bld, 45kg, 167 cm

Joint membership

Spouse: Ringo L Baker

Acct. No. 448399969

It was eight in the morning when Glenn finally got home. The television shouted at him as he entered. "And now, for you folks at home, your choices are: the red button, the green button, the blue button, or, if you're feeling lucky, the mystery button."

Glenn's parents watched intently as the emcee gave an expansive wave toward the curtain which was opening behind him. Each had their remotes firmly in hand. His mother, hair pinned tightly in cello curlers, glanced nervously from her remote to the four-cycle incinerator which sparkled on the television screen. "Red, green, or blue?" she whispered, tapping her lips with an index finger. She wouldn't risk the mystery button, but his father, morning hair in disarray, one slipper on and one slipper off, always took the chance.

Glenn reviewed the procedures quickly but with no real interest. He touched the ESC key and his monitor dimmed out. The cursor returned to the upper left hand corner of the screen and blinked a luminous blue.

About that Time Larry awoke. "These night shifts are killing me," he yawned.

"If you feel that bad go take a doze in the oven."

"No I don't feel that bad," he chuckled.

Glenn took out a vitamin smoke, the last one in his pack. Ignoring the \$10,000 purchase coupon he tossed the pack in the minizap.

He lit the cigarette and inhaled deeply, getting a slight rush as the nutritious smoke filled his lungs.

"Question."

"Shoot."

"What do you do if you can't find a part of the victim? Say...his leg is missing or something."

"Depends on the part," Larry said. "The oven will take care of any external limbs: hands, feet, arms, legs, blah blah blah. That's all automated—didn't they teach you this in tech school?"

"No. Mutilations weren't very popular then."

"That shouldn't have mattered. You never know when the customers will change their tastes."

"True, but I didn't write the training program. I just learned what they taught me."

"It was like that when I went through," Larry said. "Damn space-cases were running the school. We had this one instructor who was into asphyxiation jobs. Had us practicing artificial respiration and CPR. Talk about disgusting. Those techniques went out with radical surgery."

Glenn nodded. He'd heard the story before. "Okay, so the oven will take care of external limbs. That's all in the B code right? What about internal organs?"

"Internal organs are no different. Though you should do a brain sweep to erase the memory of the organ's removal, according to customer recall preference of course. Some people like to remember everything so they feel like they've gotten their money's worth. After that the oven will take care of everything else. If you don't do the scan the customer could go into shock and die. Not a problem if you've got a signed waiver, however. If that happens you'll have to start all over again. And you'll get a nice lecture on cost control from the

front office."

"You have to encode the brain sweep. The ones at school did that themselves."

"Newer models. Those things can do everything but return the spirit."

Glenn took another drag from his smoke. "I wonder if they'll ever be able to do that."

"Eventually."

"How?"

"If I knew that I'd be an engineer instead of just an operator."

"There was an article about it in the Center Times," Glenn said.

"They..."

"You read that garbage?"

"Not much else to do around here on midshift."

As if to make a liar of him Larry's monitor blinked and the response beacon sounded. "Ah, hell," Larry moaned.

"What is it?"

"Let's see," Larry tapped his keyboard. "Salisbury Park. Whitney Street. Not the best part of town. One Daisy Baker has just bit the dust."

"Well?"

"Well what?"

"Aren't you going to respond?"

"Noo...you're going to respond. Rule number two: Trainees always get the crap work."

"Oh, got ya. Send the info to the van, will you?"

Larry punched his keyboard and repositioned his feet as Glenn slid on his jacket and left for the parking garage.

Glenn stepped out into the darkness as a crack of thunder echoed through the center's parking lot. He shook his head and rubbed his chin as he climbed into the company van. He knew it. Every time his sensor itched it meant rain. He just hoped he could get to the body before it started pouring. Nothing like a soaking wet corpse to ruin a perfectly boring evening.

The green lights around the van began to glow as it lifted silently into the midnight sky.

* * *

Ringo Baker looked down at the body of his dead wife. He dropped the white nylon strangle rope that came with the

*Nothing like a
soaking wet
corpse to ruin a
perfectly boring
evening.*

she giggled. "Fight! Fight!"

Ringo reached into his jacket pocket. Glenn saw the knife clearly, a sliver of light in the dim parking lot. Even as he brought his arms up to block the thrust he knew he did not have a chance. He was no match for Ringo's strength and the knife slid easily through his guard. He gasped as the blade entered his chest.

The last thing he saw before he toppled into darkness was Daisy, standing on tip-toes, kissing Ringo madly.

Forty-two minutes later he was dead.

Larry stuffed the last bite of a sloppy ham, roast beef, and cheese sandwich into his mouth. He wiped his hands on his pants and punched the eject button

on the oven.

"How do you feel?"

"Headache."

"Normal. It'll pass."

"So, how did I do?"

"Not bad for a rush order."

Glenn stretched his arms overhead. "I think I could have fought a little better at the end there."

"Don't worry about it. They got their money's worth."

"You don't think they'll complain?"

"They rarely do," Larry said.

"You know something? I really did like her. She was beautiful."

"Larry shook his head, pulled a piece of roast beef from his teeth with his tongue. "I don't want to hear that. Rule number one: Don't get personally involved with the customers."



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Morgan laughed and the Captain let out another big hee-haw.

"This wasn't just a dead guy," Eddie said pointing at the Captain, looking serious. "There was more to him. He was like some imaginary guy. He wore a red and gold suit of some sort with black slippers. The suit had all sorts of designs on it. And there were bones sticking out of his legs. And, oh, get this, he was wearing a belt that had a sword attached to it."

"He was wearing a sword?" Morgan asked.

"He had a long mustache," Eddie said rubbing his mustache with his thumb and forefinger.

"You're serious?" Morgan asked.

"Yeah, I'm serious. Gus is dealing with the strange man. He's down by the lake."

The Captain lifted his head up and turned to Eddie. "Why didn't you say Gus was down there before?"

"What do you care?" Eddie asked.

"The Chinese man is dead though?" Morgan asked.

"As dead as I've seen," Eddie said and laughed.

Eddie reached over the counter and grabbed the whiskey bottle. He filled up his glass.

"It's so damned strange, Morgan. Think of it. That guy didn't belong here. Yet he shows up and causes all sorts of headache," Eddie said.

"What headache? The man was already dead. Not much a dead man can do," the Captain said and stood up.

Morgan got up and walked to the door. His jeans were loose against his waist again. He turned and saw the Captain staring in the direction of Reba's room. Eddie raised his glass. "To the drowned Chinese acrobat," he said.

Morgan walked out of the lodge a bit unsteadily, listening to Eddie's voice fade, talking about the best acrobatics he had ever seen.

From a distance the men at the dock looked like silhouettes. Morgan started down the path toward them until a Jeep pulled

up behind him and cast its lights across the dirt path to the dock. Morgan turned to see the sheriff behind him.

"Morgan," the paunchy sheriff said pulling his flashlight from his belt. "You guys got a body for me to see?" he asked. Then he leaned into the car and grabbed a clipboard.

Morgan was surprised. "I guess so," he said.

Morgan stumbled down the path, leading the sheriff to the main dock. The glow of the fires reflected in the water. Gus and the fire marshal stood over a corpse stretched across a blue tarp

on the dock. The sheriff shook hands with both men. The fire marshal leaned down

next to the body and recited details

for the sheriff to write down. Gus

pushed Dakota away from the

body with his foot.

Dakota's perked his ear.

Gus looked up at

Morgan. "What are you

doing down here,

Morgan?"

"Just seeing if I can

help," Morgan said.

"Did you have any

luck in the woods

today?" Gus asked.

Morgan ignored him.

He stepped around the

sheriff and looked down at

the body. The drowned

Chinese man was bloated and

waterlogged. There were bones

jutting out from his legs, tears in his

clothing, and all over his exposed flesh were little holes and

marks as though fish had been picking at him. And, as Eddie

said, there was a sword in a worn black sheath attached to his

belt. But strangest of all, the man had a deer antler tied to a

strip of rawhide around his neck.

"So, you never seen him before?" the sheriff asked Gus. Morgan

wondered if anyone had ever seen anything like him before.

"No, never."

"He never rented from you?"

"No."

"Never had permission to hunt or fish on this property?"

"No. You thinking poacher?" Gus asked.

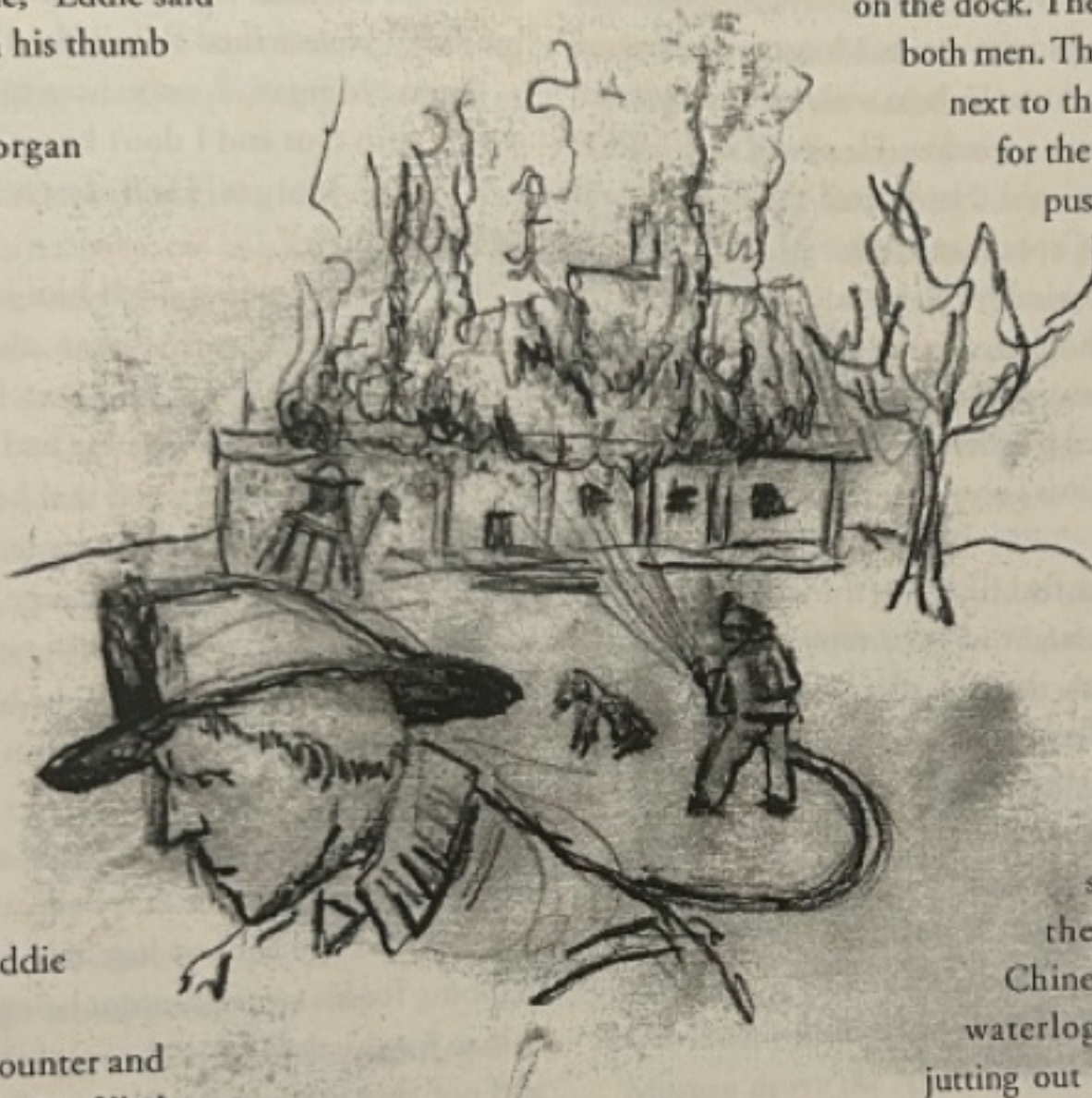
The sheriff and fire marshal laughed. "No, no," the sheriff

paused, "probably wouldn't dress like this to sneak around."

"It's the strangest thing I've seen around here," Gus said, still

looking down at the drowned Chinese man. "He ain't from

around here."



thing, I'm looking down the stone chimney of this cabin and Dakota is at the bottom on his hind legs, his front paws leaning against the inside of the chimney, looking up at me."

"So Dakota is in the cabin," the Captain said. "That's odd."

"That's not all. I hear a voice I don't recognize talking to Dakota. It's saying 'What is it boy?' And Dakota disappears and I see the back of a man's head. He turns around, looks up the chimney and it's Gus, except he's clean shaven and looks to be a lot younger. But I know it's Gus," she said with her eyes still closed. "I know it's him somehow."

"Did he say anything?" the Captain asked, crunching out his cigarette in an ashtray.

"No, just gave me a puzzled look like he didn't recognize me, a look you'd give a stranger. Then, I heard Dakota barking again and that's what I woke to. My window was open and Dakota was out barking at something. Probably chasing away raccoons or whatever has been getting into our garbage."

Morgan watched the Captain look at her, squinting. He seemed to pay close attention and Morgan thought maybe he made sense of the dream. Reba opened her eyes and looked directly at the Captain, probably because he was the only one that let her know someone was listening, Morgan thought. But they shared a look of sorrow for a moment.

"Let me tell Morgan what I saw today," Eddie said.

-32- "I don't know," Reba said, putting her hands up in the air, "it seemed so strange to me." She was still talking about the dream and ignored Eddie.

"Can you make any sense of it Morgan?" Reba asked.

Morgan wanted to say something intriguing. He wanted to be somebody Reba found interesting.

"I don't know. Maybe the fire is going to go out, or maybe God is going to bring on the floods to punish us. I heard that was supposed to happen sometime," he said.

Reba rested her elbows against the counter and looked down at the floor. Morgan looked at her eyes. She looked off somewhere then sighed. Morgan, flustered, wanted to turn away and go to his cabin and sleep.

"I just don't know what to make of it," she said and unscrewed the bottle of whiskey. She filled up all of their glasses then leaned against the counter, supporting herself on her palms.

"Do you think the cabin was sinking?" the Captain asked raising his eyebrows. Reba took a big gulp. She didn't answer the Captain but she looked at him sadly. Eddie was getting drunk and impatient. Reba picked up her glass and kept looking at the Captain.

"You guys ready?" Eddie asked, still wanting to tell his story. The Captain looked over at him. "Christ, Eddie," he said.

"I'm going to go write the dream down. Maybe that dream book from the library will help figure it out," she said. She

walked across the cabin and into her bedroom. Morgan stared at her as she walked away, the erection painful against his jeans. He looked over at the Captain and Eddie. They were staring at her, too.

"Get this," Eddie said.

"Here it comes," the Captain said resting his head on one hand and smoking a cigarette with the other.

"I swear it happened. Ask Dan, he'll tell you," Eddie said turning to the Captain. Then he turned back to Morgan. "I swear it happened."

"What did, Eddie?" Morgan asked. He felt dizzy. Drinking wasn't something he was accustomed to.

"I was on the other side of the lake. You know, the hot side, and I was making barricades with Dan. We were stacking up big bags of sand, those heavy fucking things, trying to neutralize the damned fires. Stop them from spreading."

"So we have this one barricade stable and Dan comes over to me to see what area we need to go to next. You know, I get to carry the clipboard with the objectives and all."

Morgan turned toward a window and stared at the distant blaze wondering if putting out the fire was on the list. If they put as much water on the fire as they did whiskey in their bellies then maybe I wouldn't have to hear this drunk talk, Morgan thought. He was less interested since Reba left.

"Morgan, you listening?" Eddie asked. "You dreaming again?"

"Yeah, sure."

"So I'm pointing out what needs to be done and one of the small planes swoops over us. You know how loud those things are, so we looked up. It starts dumping water. And then . . . you ain't gonna believe this. Then . . . I tell you this happened. Then, this corpse comes tumbling out with the rest of the water. It was the strangest damned thing I ever seen. It looked like some dummy or big puppet or something, and it was flipping in all directions. So it lands right on the border and I'm looking at Dan and he's looking at me. We don't know what the hell to say."

"And what did you do Edward?" the Captain asked, his voice muffled by the countertop.

"I told you already. I ran into the fire and dragged the body out into the clearing where me and Dan are standing."

"You went into the fire?" Morgan asked in disbelief.

"What was I supposed to do? I had my suit on. It was quick," Eddie said. "Dan's a medic. He'd been able to attend to me if I got hurt."

"And what kind of patient did you bring Dan, Edward?" the Captain asked.

"It was a drowned Chinese man."

"You saved a dead guy?" Morgan asked.

the tops of their hands. Eddie said the disinterested barkeep eventually interrupts and to cheer him up says there are more fish in the sea. Eddie said he told the man in the bowling shirt to keep the tackle in the boat because Kirk was the captain of the only vessel catching anything. Eddie said the man fell over drunk when he tried to punch him.

Morgan stepped into the lodge and looked over at the bar. He saw Eddie hitting the top of it, laughing, and the Captain shook his head and looked down into the ice of his drink. Across the small bar Reba leaned under a stuffed otter. She wore a flannel shirt and tight blue jeans. The

top button of her shirt was undone and when she bent forward there was room to glimpse at the shapes contained within. The Captain said something and pointed at Eddie, and Reba laughed, her face blooming red. Morgan couldn't help looking over the curves the jeans molded to. He felt the warm beginning sensation of an erection. There were times when Reba did things to Morgan in his mind.

A glow of orange and yellow light reflected in the through the lodge windows.

Morgan walked up to the bar where Eddie was on the defensive and Reba laughed. She slapped the Captain on the shoulder and wiped a tear with the underside of her pinkie. Eddie looked frustrated, but his brows arched when he saw Morgan approach.

"Pour Morgan one," Eddie said to Reba. "Morgan, you gotta hear this."

"I'm all right," Morgan said looking at Eddie's mustache and dirty face. "I'm actually pretty tired and thinking about getting some sleep."

"Come on Morgan, catch up," Reba said.

Morgan reached for the glass and his hand grazed Reba's. His erection flexed against his jeans. He sniffed the glass. It was strong, but because Reba looked at him and the depth of her brown eyes seemed to make excuses for him, he took a big gulp and held in the burning cough.

"Check this out, Morgan. You won't believe what came from the lake today," Eddie said.

"Don't worry, Morg. We got official word that Nessy was D.O.A. so Edward here didn't have to try and save it," the Captain said. He poked his finger into Eddie's chest then let out this big hee-haw sort of southern laugh that hurt Morgan's

ears. Reba squealed and smacked the Captain on the shoulder again.

Morgan smiled. "What was it? Pike? Bass? Walleye?"

Reba and the Captain exchanged glances. Morgan pivoted away from them on his stool and looked at the empty area of wood paneling that was a waiting home for the future mount. He thought about the deformity of his kill. It puzzled him what would have taken an antler, taken a part of something that took so much time to grow and develop. He didn't know how to justify it. For meat, he thought. But it didn't seem right.

"Morgan. You with us man?" Eddie asked.

"Were you dreaming, Morgan? You were dreaming. What of?" Reba asked.

"I was just thinking. Not dreaming. My mind was wandering, that's all," Morgan said.

"Oh, I'm remembering a dream I had last night," Reba said pressing her fingers to her temples with her eyes closed. She tried to make sense of her dreams.

She tapped her temples, looking for details. She leaned her head back and her shirt tightened against her breasts. Morgan imagined doing things to them in his mind. He had never touched them

before. Eddie stared. The Captain brought out a smoke, then looked over at Morgan, glanced at Reba, and smiled as he lit the cigarette.

Eddie seemed to sip his drink in frustration. He looked bothered by Reba interrupting his story.

"Oh, oh," Reba said quickly as if it was coming to her. "It's night time. I'm on a roof of one of the cabins. And I'm in my blue nightgown staring at the moon. There are strange things happening on the moon so far away. I can't tell what it is but somehow in my mind I know it's not right."

Eddie snorted and rolled his eyes. Reba kept hers close. The Captain chopped Eddie in the chest with the back of his hand. Morgan adjusted on the stool, trying to find a comfortable position.

"Yes, and, oh," Reba continued, "the strange thing is that I'm on the roof of a cabin but the cabin is somehow moving back and forth. I look down from the moon and this cabin is floating in so much water, it seems to cover just about everything. I look around and can only see the tops of trees and the moon. Then I hear a dog barking. It's sounds like Dakota, but I look around and can't see where it's coming from. But there's barking. Next



Morgan take the high-paying customers. The cold air numbed his face. The sun was masked in smoke. Gus had both hands on the wheel and stared forward into the abysmal morning. They stopped at the tree line. Morgan stepped out and leaned the rifle against his shoulder.

"Morgan," Gus said. "I know I can count on you when I need to." He paused and glanced at the treetops where the smoke choked the horizon. "Find us a hell of a buck."

Beyond the rushing planes and helicopters, and the loud splashes of their descent on the lake, Morgan ambled into the woods with his rifle. His intention was to help Gus perpetuate a dying dream. A monster buck might draw hunters to the lodge despite the spreading fire across the lake, or so Gus believed.

There were many animal tracks and scat piles, but none lead him to a tree rub or matted down grass, anything that would suggest a deer had been around. They're spooked, Morgan thought. He reached out and broke branches, blazing his own path back to the ATV. It was in that moment of reverie that Morgan, out of the corner of his eyes, saw a deer about forty yards away, slaloming the trunks of leafless trees.

-30- Morgan raised his rifle, shoving the butt of it into his shoulder. He flexed his pectoral muscle to steady it. The deer hustled by blurred images of dark trees in the cross hairs of the rifle scope. It looked to be a trophy kill; maybe even a 12-point. Morgan breathed deeply. When his arms settled, he squeezed the trigger and smoke enveloped the image of the athletic animal sliding across fallen, browned leaves.

After roughly 30-minutes Morgan found the deer on its side in a pile of twigs and leaves. He kicked it lightly in the ribs, making sure it was dead, then, as he had seen Gus do many times, he wedged his boot under the deer's head and lifted it to count the points on the rack. When he turned its head from the leaves he found only a nub of an antler—a smooth white circle of bone edged with dried red and black tissue. It looked too smooth to have been broken off. On top of its head was Chinese lettering branded between the nub and the whole antler.

Morgan pulled a knife from his belt and cut the deer down its chest to its belly. He pushed his hands into the cut. A wet squishing sound belched as he pulled out the entrails with a bandanna tied around his face to thwart the intrusive smell. He felt by the deer he killed, which with one antler wouldn't make a good mount. Bringing a freak deer back to Gus wouldn't support that "everything's all right" facade he wore like a tacky life preserver. Morgan tried convincing himself that Gus couldn't really expect him to bring back a deer and he probably just didn't want people brooding around the lodge all day.

Morgan stood up and put both hands on his lower back. He stretched backward and yawned, staring at the distant fire

between the gaps in the trees. Morgan felt the paranoia that came from being alone in the woods. It's the kind of paranoia a child gets struggling to sleep by itself, turning all the dark objects of its bedroom into monsters. There was still a chance of encountering a black bear and Morgan wondered if leaving the sad, deformed creature was the thing to do, to leave it there next to puddles of blood and guts where grubs and other unseen parasites could feast on it.

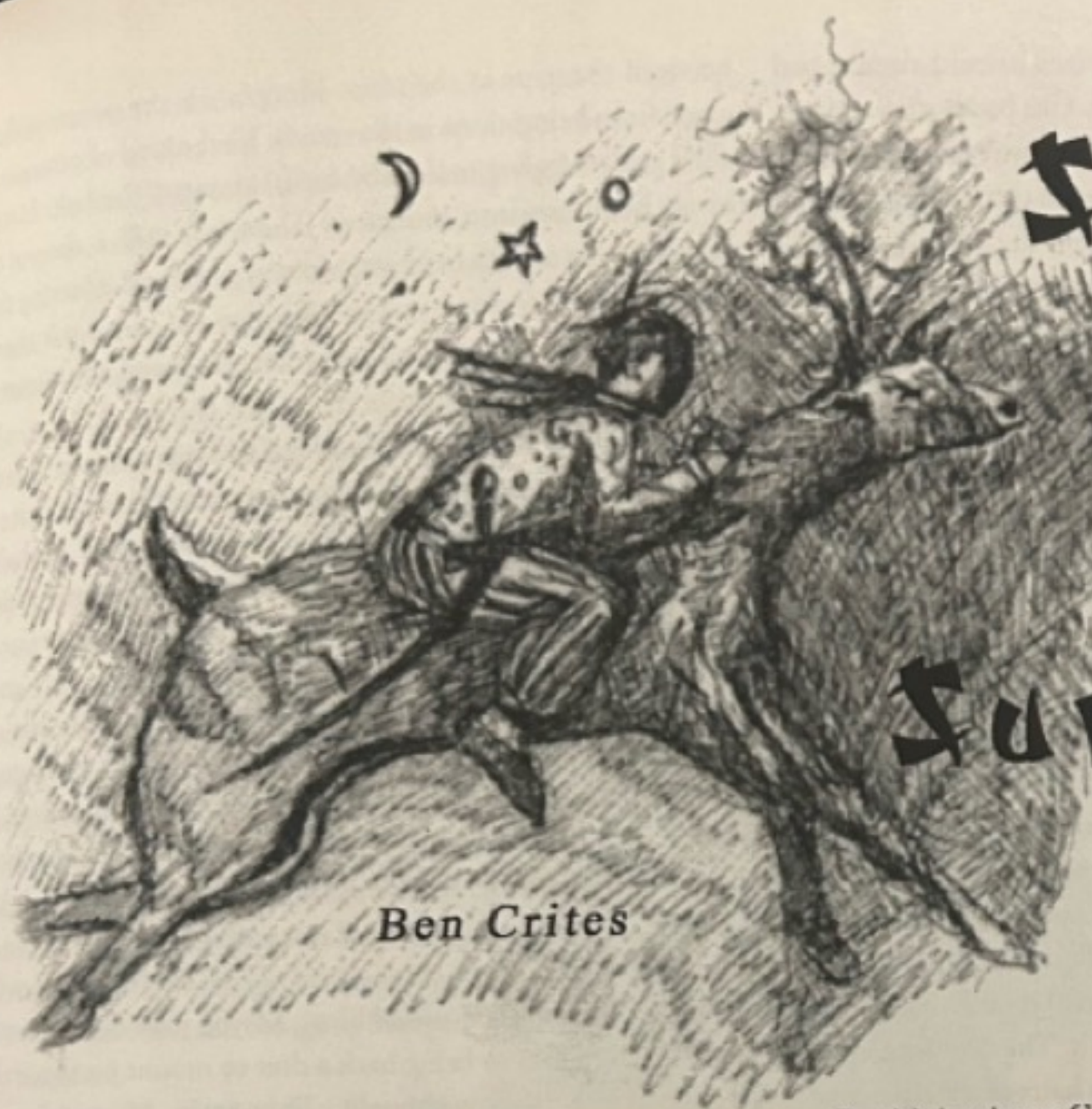
Gripping the deer by its hind legs, Morgan dragged it over moss covered stones and dead wood, working his way back to the path where Gus would pick him up. He thought Gus could at least sell some of the meat to his customers; maybe make some venison sausage for gift baskets. He stumbled over rusted cans and corroded logs that broke apart, freeing ants and centipedes. Dragging the deer cut a line through the debris of fallen leaves, exposing fresh dirt dark as coffee grinds. He hoped no one would draw attention to the missing antler. Gus would, no doubt, but Morgan guessed the firemen at the lodge bar flirting with Gus's wife, Reba, might rib him, especially if drinks had been poured. In the course of two weeks Morgan became a younger brother to two firefighters. They rubbed his head, messed up his hair, and teased him. Maybe they didn't know that Gus asked him to bring back a deer to mount on the wall by the fireplace, Morgan thought. Then again, Morgan knew how Reba liked to talk and he also knew that it was hard not to pay attention, to watch her breasts move in her shirt with each deep breath and sigh.

The deer's tongue dangled out of its mouth. It was dry and curled like a shoehorn. Morgan waited on Gus for several hours. He watched airplanes scoop water from the lake. He heard the echoes of shouting firefighters. He paced the path. He traced his fingers along the Chinese writing on the deer's head. The woods grew dark. Morgan decided to walk back to the main lodge.

The fire loomed in the slurred stories droning from surly firemen, their faces masked with residue of pine smoke, accentuating the white of their eyes.

The night before, Morgan bonded with some of the firemen who worked at the perimeter of the blaze to hinder its movement. One of them, a thick guy with a dark face and thin mustache named Eddie, talked fast and was full of stories. It took two whiskey and waters to get the entertainment going.

Morgan remembered Eddie tell him a story about the other fireman, Kirk, the "Captain" as Eddie called him. Eddie told Morgan he and Kirk were at a bar in town and a man with a bowling shirt got soused and cried about the divorce he was going through. Eddie said the bartender tried to ignore it, but he and Kirk are muffling their laughter by pressing their lips to



Strange Forms of the Surfacing Dead

Ben Crites

Morgan saw flames glisten in Gus's eyes.

Gus, a stout, compulsively bearded man who ran the Missauga Recreation Camp, watched all the birch and maple trees—so many that wore the wounds of his hatchet from blazing paths to fallen deer—cough up smoke into the pink skyline.

Morgan stood beside him, fighting off the webs of sleep by rubbing his eyelids with his thumbs. The ATV sputtered behind them. Gus limped through the moist sand of the receding shoreline with his arms folded. A loon sang down the shore. Gus, a man of few precise words, had withdrawn most of his thoughts since the fire began.

Morgan didn't know what started it. The fires appeared one morning out of the fog that fringed the opposite side of the lake and now Morgan gazed in bleary wonder as he zipped up his orange hunting vest.

The fire's impact manifested in the declining water level, which now exposed more mud and dried-up moss. Docks needed little ladders like those in swimming pools to access the anchored boats. The beach was a bone yard of driftwood, jagged rocks, dead walleye and bass, everything brittle and pungent.

Morgan wanted to sleep and ignore the fires. He could float in a dream where things normally didn't make sense. But buzzing engines of planes and helicopters, scooping water to douse the fire kept Morgan awake through the night.

But his loyalty to Gus, Morgan could not dream that away. To Gus, this wasn't the end of his Missauga.

Gus panned the shoreline. He lifted a bluegill up with his boot and nodded at Morgan. Gus's foxhound, Dakota, sniffed it.

"We'll get through this," he said. Morgan yawned and nodded back.

Morgan lived in a cabin rent free because of an old favor Gus had promised Morgan's father. There was a hunting accident. Morgan's father, at the time a customer, dragged Gus out of the woods after his Remington rifle misfired and buried a bullet in his thigh. Cancer stole Morgan's father and the opportunity to repay the favor.

Gus told Morgan things would change, that they would still have a busy hunting season, all the while Gus's empire burned to the ground behind him. The lingering smell of wood smoke and dead fish always reminded him, but Morgan saw how Gus tried to be hopeful, how he wanted to pretend it wasn't happening.

Morgan loaded a bullet into the chamber of his rifle. He would go into the woods opposite of the burning end of the lake, and he would kill. He would do it because Gus asked him to, because he couldn't tell him no.

Morgan bounced in the ATV as Gus navigated him to a tree line of black pine and oaks; a productive hunting spot Gus had

When the man and the boy were fifty yards from the old man at his window, and the setting sun had lit the bottoms of the clouds on fire, the old man called out to them. "Hello there!"

The pair stopped and the boy cried out, grasping his father's wrist. The strong man shushed him and grasped the axe mid-haft, approaching the cottage with his weathered brow knotted like thick rope. "What ghost haunts these ruins?" he called out.

"No ghost," called the old man, "just a man who has lived a long long time. A man who has defeated death." Hearing the words coming from his lips the old man felt a sort of subdued jubilation, and he laughed. It was a coarse, empty sound.

The strong man stopped a dozen paces from the cottage. "When I was a boy and cut the trees with my father, a very old man lived in this grove, alone in a failing cottage. But that was many years ago and my father was a baby when the old man who lived here began to lose his hair, and my father crossed the river out of this world nine years ago."

-38- "Ah, but I outsmarted the reaper," explained the old man. "On the day I watched you and your father cut the trees here long ago, I began to imagine the ways I might die, thus preventing them. I have imagined every possibility, and now I never need to fear death again." The old man grinned, delighted with himself.

The strong man rested the head of the axe on the ground and thought back. "I remember that day. That was the day that this cottage caught fire and burned up. The sheriff came and examined it a few days later and determined that the old man who had lived here must have fallen asleep while something was still burning, a candle or the stove or a pipe. I think, old ghost, that you forgot to imagine the possibility that you were dead before you began."

The old man was silent. Indeed, he had never considered the possibility. He blinked and looked about at the ruins of his cottage. Grasses and weeds grew everywhere, sprouting from upturned stones. Mosses choked the blackened, worm-eaten fragments of lumber that had once been walls. A small sapling, green and brisk, sprouted through the eye socket of a sun-bleached skull.



but he had no mouth to cry out with, and he felt a heavy fear and sadness weighing on his heart. He thought, if only I had imagined this first it wouldn't have happened this way.

When he awoke the sun had risen from his view but the dream remained crystalline and visible. He thought for a while about the relationship between his dream and his maxim. With the patience and determination that only the old have, he made up his mind then to foresee and imagine all the possibilities of his death so that he might prevent it from ever happening. He began to turn the cogs of his tired and dusty imagination, bringing to picturesque clarity in his mind's eye the circumstances of his own demise. He imagined himself falling down and striking his left temple, then his right. Then he imagined his exhausted heart pumping away in his ribcage, and he imagined it giving one final lurch, then halting. He imagined this happening while he slept, while he breakfasted, while he carried pails of water from the banks of a nearby stream.

He imagined a thousand different killers: robbers, pirates, and madmen. They were of all different ages, different skin colors, different temperaments, and carried different weapons. Each of them killed him a thousand different ways, piercing this organ or that, smothering him or poisoning him or simply dashing his fragile head against the oaken floor. He imagined every possible disease or malady that chance might carry on a breeze to his lungs or his skin or his belly or mind.

Days passed and the old man still sat in his chair, his imagination rolling more vividly than a child's. At one point he feared he might starve to death or wither up and perish from lack of water. So he imagined the gory details of his body consuming itself, imagined the thickening of his blood as the water in it dried up. He imagined every species of bird flying into his window to peck at his eyes and tear strips of his brain from hollow sockets. He thought of every animal he had ever seen and those he had only heard of and some he simply imagined. He witnessed rats crawling in through the cracks to bite the flesh from his bones and elephants trampling over his house, the beams of the cottage crushing his lungs, his head, his heart.

Seasons passed and the old man's imagination worked on tirelessly, without food or drink or rest. He had long ago imagined the possibility of dying in his sleep, or dying from lack thereof, and thus evaded these hooded spectres. As his eyes tracked the passage of years he imagined every assault of nature, from earthquakes and tornadoes to hailstones of every size puncturing the failing thatch roof and clubbing him to death. He went so far as to imagine volcanoes rising up in the nearby hills and rocks and stars falling from the heavens, just to be safe.

His mind was continually at work vividly imagining his own violent or peaceful death. Occasionally in the back of his mind he might feel surprise at some particular method, in that he had not imagined it sooner, such as the cold night in autumn when he first imagined himself freezing to death. He had developed a system to keep track of which possibilities he had happened across, carefully categorizing every method and all the particulars of that method. He even imagined safety nets for himself. For example, he imagined himself forgetting certain possibilities that he had already imagined and losing his careful system. He even imagined the possibility that for a hundred different reasons he might forego his battle against the final imperative of life, and simply give up. He played out the possibility that he might forget to imagine some circumstance or other, thus insuring that he would continue on until he had exhausted every possibility.

*His arms were
raised aloft,
palms facing
the sky as he
felt the vicious
flames lick at
his ankles.*

He spent an entire year (although he knew no time, his entire memory was consumed in the details of his painstaking system) imagining different ways other people might take his life. Wars were fought across his lawn, cannibals came and gobbled up his organs, sucking the marrow from his bones and dancing around in the ruins of the old cottage. Mobs of zealots stormed his home, tortured him, hanged him, crucified him. They accused him of witchcraft, of demonic possession, denouncing him as a heretic and even as a martyr. He imagined the simple failings that are unexpected—the rotting of his house and his subsequent terminal fall, the legendary storm of frogs smothering him in their splattered green corpses, and

allergic reactions to bee stings.

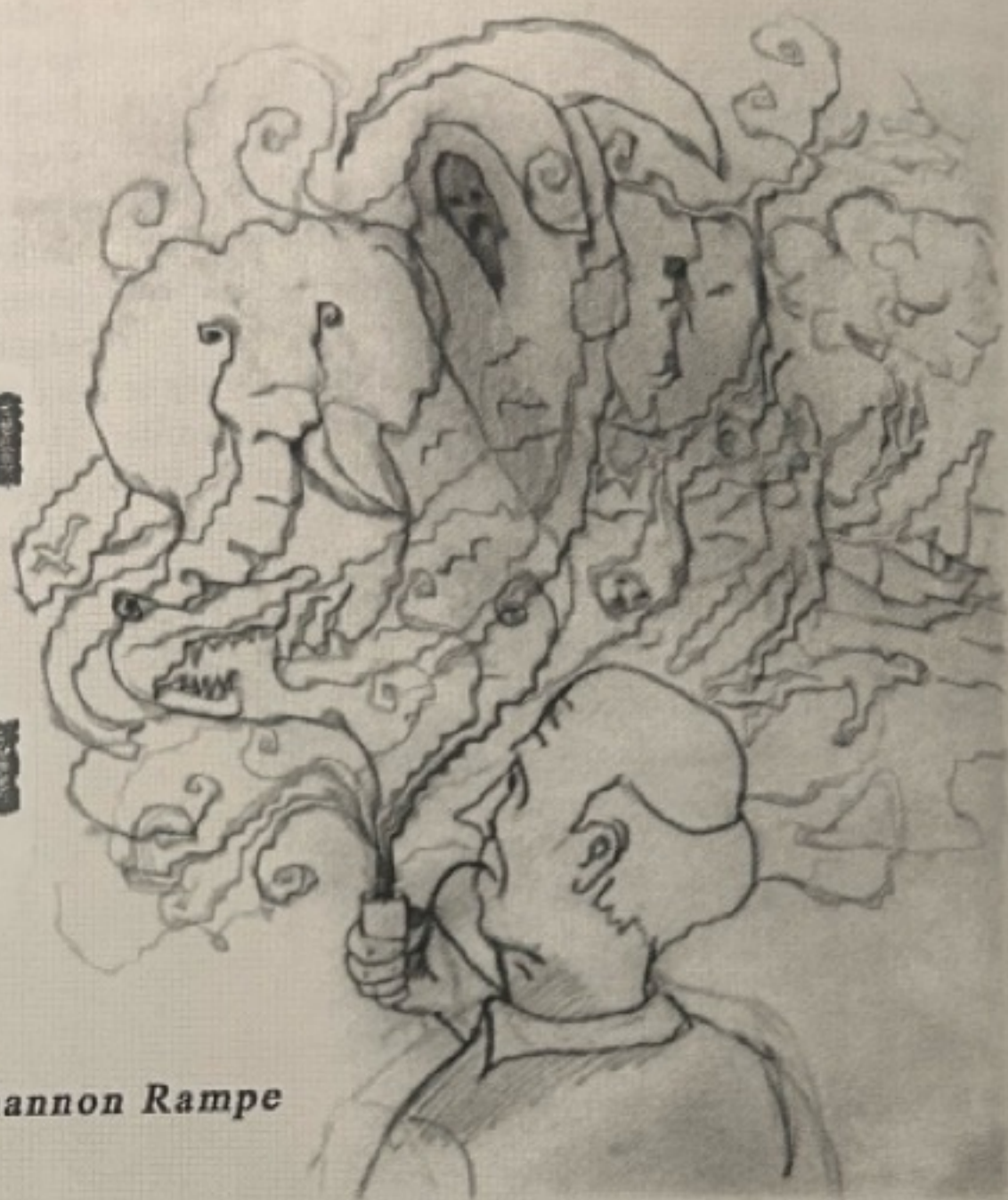
One spring morning he came to a halt, imagining a great forest fire sweeping across the countryside and his skin blackening and turning to ash among the waves of flame. The old man remembered this scenario and realized that he had come full circle. He sighed and looked out his window at the distant forest of the hill in the northeast. He saw a strong man and his boy, hewing at a tree with an axe. They brought to his mind a very distant memory, and he saw in the man's face the boy he had seen so long ago on the day he had first foreseen his death. He saw that this boy had a likeness to this man in the same way that distant child had resembled the former strong man.

The old man smiled and let his mind rest finally. He simply watched the man and the boy as they hewed the morning into late afternoon. The distant pair had cut and stacked a dozen large poles of wood, each carefully stripped of its branches. The man said something to the boy and the latter nodded. Then the two started across the hill through the wild grasses that surrounded the old man's cottage.

The Man Who Died

A Thousand Deaths

Shannon Rampe



-36-

"He reflected that reality does not usually coincide with our anticipation of it, with a logic of his own he inferred that to foresee a circumstantial detail is to prevent its happening."

-Jorge Luis Borges, "The Secret Miracle"

A very old man sat by the window of his cottage one morning and gazed out across the grassy meadow. On a distant hill he watched a broad-shouldered man and his boy hewing at a tree with their axes. He counted each swing and a moment later the chucking thud met his ears.

He lit a battered pipe and leaned back, thinking of the very old trees, and how if no one came to cut them down, the behemoths might just keep growing forever. He felt a sorrow for the trees and a likening to them. He knew that his own end was coming soon and the thought of it made his stomach churn and twist itself into knots. In his youth he was daring and foolhardy, as youth often are, never fearing death because he had never felt her in the ache of his wrists and knees, never heard her in his gravelly cough, never seen her in the liver spots on his skin. Until he grew old.

The old man drew on the pipe and blew out a delicate ring of smoke. It hovered in the morning sunlight, curling and spreading

wider until a passing zephyr pulled it out the window. He thought then of all he had learned in his life, reliving all the trials and hardships in an effort to understand himself after all those years. He wanted just one maxim, one simple but profound bit of knowledge that he could be content with as he went to his grave. After a long time he spoke aloud, to no one in particular, or perhaps to the birds. "When one anticipates an event, the actual event is never as one imagines it." Turning this gem over and over in his mind, as a child rolls a bit of candy on her tongue, he drifted into an uneasy sleep.

He dreamed of a fire that swept across the hills and burned up all the ancient trees in the forest. The heat was so intense that he felt his own skin dry up and crack as he watched. He tried to run but his joints were knotted up, and looking down he saw that his feet had become roots sunk into the loamy earth. His arms were raised aloft, palms facing the sky as he felt the vicious flames lick at his ankles. The pain was excruciating.

Morgan awoke early that morning, pulled on his jeans, and snuck over to the garage to borrow the ATV. He attached the trailer and rattled along the dirt path in the woods. He saw hooves jutting out from the prairie grass. The deer was covered in flies. Morgan grabbed it by its antler and hefted its upper body into the trailer. He then hoisted its lower section in and rubbed his fingers along the Chinese lettering. Its tongue still drooped out of its mouth.

Morgan stopped at the top of a hill. Down below, a group of firefighters gathered in front of the lodge. The fire raged far behind them. He squinted closely and saw Dakota running around and barking. Then there was Gus pointing a shotgun at the firefighters.

Morgan drove down the hill and beeped the horn on the ATV. He saw the men turn their faces in his direction. He stopped in between Gus and the firefighters. Gus didn't lower his shotgun. He kept it pointed at the Captain's chest.

"Move, Morgan," Gus said. He stared at the Captain. Fire danced in his eyes.

"What are you going to do, Gus?"

"I'm going to kill this man. Step aside."

"Wait a second. I think I can explain what's been going on around here. Well, I'll do my best, anyway."

The Captain swallowed, Adam's apple lurching in his throat. Eddie stood beside him, his legs shaking. Two other firefighters with lunch pails stood still.

"Things were so much better before you all came along," Gus said.

"It's the drowned Chinese man. He cursed this place, maybe even started the fire."

Everyone gave Morgan a queer look, except for Gus, who stared down the Captain.

"I know it's kind of strange. But look here." Morgan grabbed the deer by its only antler and held up its head. "This deer here, it has a word tattooed on its head in Chinese." He looked around at the men.

"And the drowned Chinese man had the same kind of lettering on his clothes. Plus, he wore a deer antler as a necklace. That's not a coincidence, boys."

Morgan bent down to lug out the deer. "What it means is that this place . . ."

The Captain stepped forward to help Morgan with the deer and Gus shot him in the guts. Morgan flinched and hit his head

on the trailer. Eddie quaked and pissed his pants. Morgan looked up and saw Reba bawling in the window. The two firefighters' lunch pails dangled on their pinkies, almost dropping. The Captain gurgled blood and stared up into the sky. A plane flew overhead. The Captain stared at it, the underside of it dark and shadowy, and by the time it passed over the woods and spewed water, he was dead. Gus stared at the plane. Morgan wondered what he might be thinking. But while transfixed on the plane, one of two firefighters hit Gus in the face with his lunch pail. The other disarmed him and pointed the shotgun at his head while Eddie ran inside and called the sheriff.

Morgan spent the next half hour on the beach with Dakota. He watched the fires smolder across the lake. A family of ducks

floated by. Morgan picked blades of grass and folded them. He plucked them, threw them up into the air, and watched them spin to the ground. A plane dove down towards the lake, scooped water, and then flew off across the lake and spilled it into the curling folds of smoke.

While the sheriff loaded Gus into the back of his Jeep, the firefighters lifted their dead friend into one of their trucks. Morgan walked up to the Jeep with Dakota. He could see the reflection of a plane flying away from the fire in the window, and behind the reflection Gus looked at Morgan and then looked past him to the fires and nodded. They drove away, up the gravel road, with Dakota yapping and racing beside them.

Morgan drove the ATV down to the shoreline. He dragged the dead deer out of the trailer and waded out into the water with it. The water was cold and smelled of dead fish. Morgan let the cold-water fill the deer's cavity and then he pushed it out and away from him, watching it sink, the antler like the mast of a sinking vessel. Morgan watched the folds of smoke rise off the woods across the lake and he wished for rain—to suffocate the fires and flood the lake again, so all the things sunk on the bottom wouldn't resurface.



"Doesn't work for the county?" the sheriff asked, turning to the fire marshal.

"Nope. He's foreign. Only foreign man I seen near Missauga," the fire marshal said.

"Never know what is gonna try to disrupt things around here," the sheriff said. "It puzzles me."

Morgan left the men to scratch their heads over it. He walked up the path to the main lodge with Dakota panting beside him, finding things to piss on. Startled, Dakota barreled toward the main lodge, his bark echoing in the woods. Morgan raced around to the side of the lodge and saw Dakota with his paws pressed against the wood underneath a window. He pawed at it. "What is it, boy? A raccoon?" he said. He quieted the dog but still heard whining. It was the Captain and Reba. Morgan stood at an angle and glanced in the window. Reba mounted the captain, her face flushed as she shook against him. Morgan stared a while and then jerked away and looked off in the distance where the fires only seemed brighter and the lake shallower. It didn't seem that anything was going to put out the fires.

Morgan lay on his bed, the fires flickering through his window. He closed his eyes and thought of Reba topless. He thought about squeezing her breasts, thought about it over and over.

There was a knock on his door.

-34-

Reba stood outside hugging herself in the cold. Morgan let her in. She smelled of apples and hickory smoke. There was still color in her cheeks.

"Sorry to bother you," she said. "I just . . . I think something is wrong with Gus."

Reba sat next to Morgan on his bed and the smell of her pervaded the cabin.

"He's distant these days," she said and began to cry. She looked down at Morgan's lap to where he adjusted his jeans.

"What do you mean?" Morgan asked.

"It feels like everything is over; that I've lost him."

"It's the fire. He's worried about losing Missauga."

"I know, but . . . there's more to it than that." She sniffled and dabbed at her eyes with a tissue. "He knows something, Morgan. Something I'm not ready to tell you."

"You can tell me," Morgan said, squeezing Reba's shoulder and smelling her hair. He tried to think of something else, something strange that could keep his mind off of Reba, but it wasn't working. His erection flexed against his jeans.

"Morgan, you're so young . . ."

Morgan kissed Reba. She was as lifeless and still as the one-antlered deer rotting on a dirt path in the woods. Morgan withdrew and looked Reba in the eyes.

"I'm sorry I did that. I'm lonely a lot of the time."

Reba stood up and edged backwards toward the door. "I know you are, Morgan. Can we just forget it happened?"

"Yeah, I suppose we should." For a while they were both quiet, mulling over what took place, not just then, but over the course of the last couple weeks. Morgan thought about his deer, that the meat would be spoiled because he left it alone for too long. He watched Reba's chest heave with each breath.

"Look, Morgan. I came here to tell you that something is wrong with Gus and I don't know if I can fix it. I need you to talk to him, Morgan. He'll always listen to you."

"What about?"

"Just hear him out and tell him it isn't worth it."

She shut the door and Morgan, alone again, fell back onto his bed. He worried about the deer he killed, that Gus might stumble on it in the woods. He had to get to it before Gus did.

For a while he felt ashamed that he had kissed Reba, but soon that feeling left him when he remembered seeing her with the Captain. He held onto that image, of Reba and the Captain naked and aggressive, until his breath shortened and he felt his pulse pound strongly throughout his entire body. He held on until the image didn't interest him anymore and a feeling of sadness came over him.

Morgan kept his eyes closed and dreamed. He imagined the drowned Chinese man trapped at the bottom of the lake, underneath large sunken logs. He imagined the Chinese man grabbing for his sword but not being able to reach it, not being able to free himself from the mess that trapped him, drowning and not able to make it to the surface of the water.

Morgan rolled over and balled up. The warmth of sleep crept over him. He imagined the drowned Chinese man riding atop the deer with one antler, galloping in the dried mud wasteland that was Lake Missauga. He saw them riding past old sunken fishing boats, past corroded treasure chests, past piles and piles of bones, past large chunks of wood with old rusted fishing lures lodged in them, and past large boulders covered in moss.

He saw them ride faster and faster past all kinds of rusted hunks of metal, and then they rose up into the sky and flew farther and farther, like this beast with one antler was some sort of magical creature and was taken the strange man home. And then there was just a large gap of mud covered with all the things the lake was hiding. Morgan fell asleep thinking of those things, things that would surface into reality without any other place to hide.

Dear Save-the-Kildans supporter,

We regret to inform you that the planet Kilda is very near the end. Recent degassing of the atmosphere has led to the spontaneous rupture of 98 percent of the Kildan population. The remainder are lining up by the hundreds to semi-painless hovering death boxes.

This is the perfect opportunity to renew your membership in Save-the-Kildans. Please send money. Please help. Sweet Jesus...it's horrifying (pictures enclosed).

Sincerely,

Meltor Manikkit

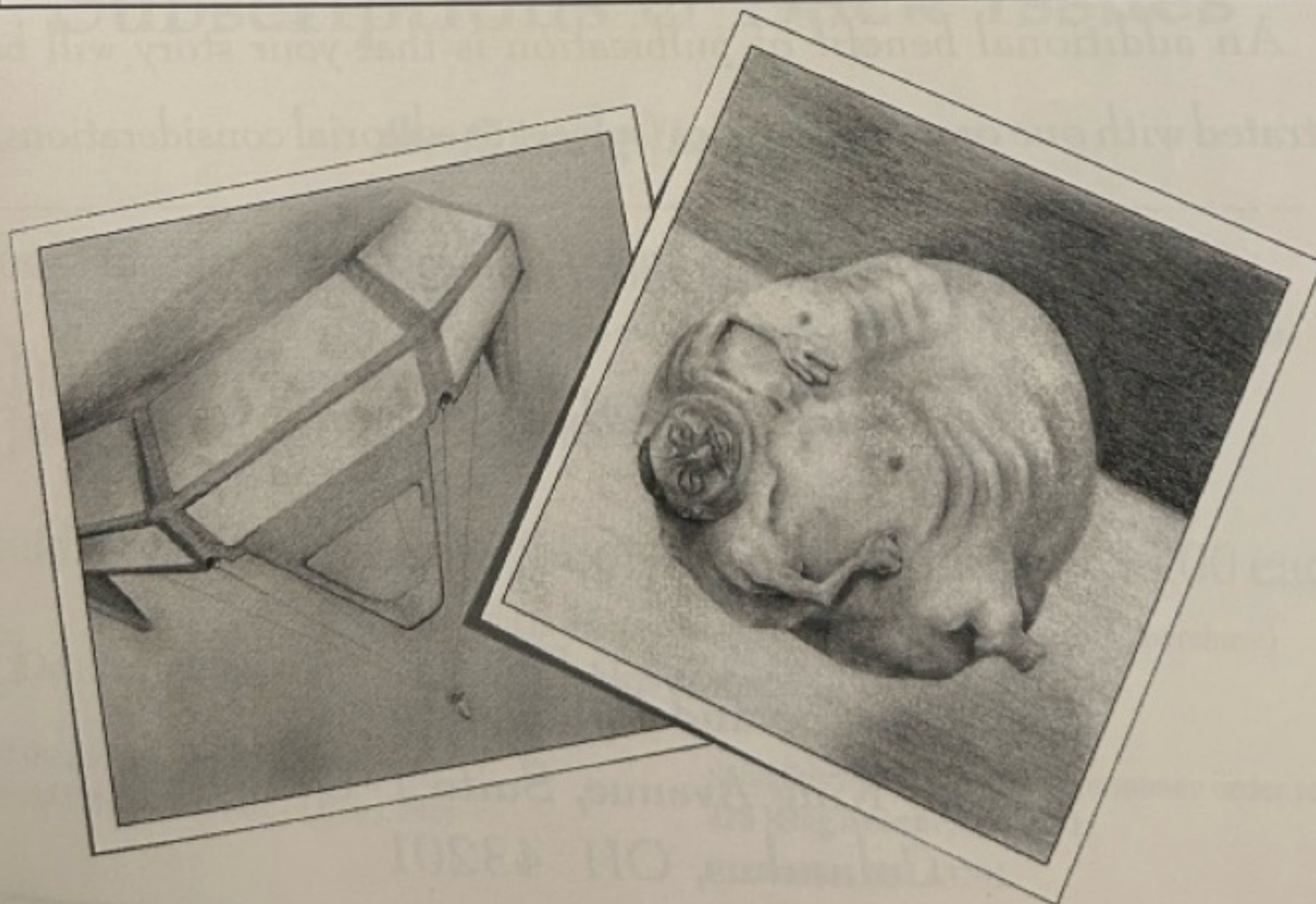
Interim President, Save-the-Kildans Foundation

Save-the-Kildans
399944994 M Street
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nathan mcknight

-43-



Save the Kildans

Dear Save-the-Kildans supporter,

Now is the time to renew your membership in Save-the-Kildans. The situation on Kilda has worsened. Here to tell you of the dire situation on planet Kilda is Neishar Sriolio, xenolinguistics student and Save-the-Kildans volunteer:

One morning, while I was at work transcribing the domestic history of a Kildan mother of eight, an explosion shook me to my pseudo-ears. With the thinning atmosphere of the planet, hab-depressurization is not an uncommon occurrence. However, this was something new. The station's floating bladder had ruptured a hydrogen line, setting off a chain reaction that sent the lower dormitories hurling towards the center of the planet. All sixty billion occupants were killed. Slowly.

I want to thank you personally for your support of my work. While on planet Kilda, I've had the opportunity to transcribe and record thousands of pages of Kildan oral literature. In this rich tome, one value is held most highly above all others. It is the Kildan tradition of giving. Since before Dissociation, it has been the Kildan practice to help any person in need, be it a friend, family member, or stranger. I know that you have it in your heart to share in this Kildan tradition and reach out a helping hand to our fellow kith. Though their hearts are bigger than your head and joined in a complex symbiotic relationship with their lungs, liver, and kidneys, they are as one with the hearts of you and I.

Now, more than ever, we need your support.

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Kef Keff

President, Save-the-Kildans Foundation

(A 336-C designated charity-type organization)

Make all checks payable to:

Save-the-Kildans

88-A Elliot Moffe Ave. NE (formerly Mestone Ave. NE)

Mohank Moffe City, Moffeland (formerly Fenfrac City, United Metanates)

55021-992

Planet Moffe (formerly Planet Qorral)

Note: We sincerely regret your ineligibility for our volunteer program. It is requested that you do not issue any further threats. Accusations of impropriety will no longer be forwarded to Mr. Keff.

Dear Mr. **Ogladorb** ,

Thank you for your interest in the Save-the-Kildans volunteer program. We regret to inform you that your application cannot be processed due to one or more of the following reasons:

- Lack of experience with foreign languages/language in general
- More than eight misdemeanors on a kith-inhabited planet
- Inappropriate paper fasteners
- Lack of accommodations for your bioclass
- Overweight
- Failure to return form 33-3290B completed
- Inhospitable weather conditions
- Illegible penmanship
- Druids
- Contaminated biopsy
- Special request of your government

We hope that you will accept our apologies for any inconvenience. We would appreciate the continuance of your support for our foundation by acting as a pen pal to any of our small troupe of translators, or by sending a contribution to the address listed below.

And now, a special message from Yaoogal-bint Tamaransitarian, Ur-Emperor of the planet Kilda:

Please help [us]. We die. We die—you live. That planet is bad us. We no not go to off the. Beg beg please help [by sending cash or money order]. My daughter. She die. Dead is my wife too. It not here good her/me/them/you(plural)/people in general. We die. Not want so. We help of you...[garbled]...then to send us of our culture. Long history is have. History is end. We is end. We die. You live. Sad. Sad. Sad. Sad.

Thank you for your support,

KefKeff

Interim President, Save-the-Kildans Foundation

Note: Please reply with Mr. **Hamlodon** 's forwarding address (under penalty of law).

Save-the-Kildans
88 Mestone Ave. NE
Fenfra City, United Metanates
55021-992
Planet Qorral

nathan mcknight

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Save the Kildans

Carefully fold and cut along dashed line (per instructions on envelope).

Name/Tattoo #: _____
(use back if necessary)

Address: _____
(street) (territory/region/owner) (planet)

Kith Class (PLEASE check ONE only):

Bipedal erect
Bipedal knucklewalking
Quadrupedal
Slither/Scurry
Sessile
Not Sure

Respiratory Mode:

Oxygen
Oxy-Hydrogen
Hydrogen
Hydrogen cyanide
Hydrogen sulfide
Heliox

Sex:

Male
Female
Hermaphroditic
Pseudo-femaloid
Sex Number 23*
Gnathostomatic
Snail-like
Asexual

Gender:

Male
Female
Hermaphroditic
Pseudo-femaloid
Sex Number 36
Gnathostomatic
Snail-like
Asexual

Do you shave? Yes No

*Illegal sexes are assured anonymity.

Save the Kildans

Nathan McKnight
illustrated by Jade



Dear Mr. or Mrs. **Hamlodon** (or current resident),

High in the clouds of the planet Kilda, a kith race is fighting a losing battle. As the Kildan sun evolves off the main sequence, it will flare up and burn the light gasses from the planet's atmosphere, with dire consequences for the population. In less than one siddecade, the Kildans will go extinct. The entire population of Kilda (an estimated 2.5 trillion individuals) will die. Escape is not an option.

They will be the first recorded human kith to go extinct in the nearly five thousand years since Dissociation. The unique condition of the Kildans precludes such measures as evacuation, either *en masse*, or selective. They are cloud dwellers, apparently evolved from an engineered form created around the time of Dissociation. The Kildans cannot save themselves because they have never developed any technology—they are giant, filter-feeding beings who float belly-up among the clouds by filling their lungs with hydrogen. Moreover, no other kith race has the means to develop vessels to house such unusual refugees in the time remaining to them.

There is nothing that can save the Kildans, but they need your help to save their culture. They are sending this urgent request to all oxygen- or hydrogen-breathing kith (unfortunately, facilities for sulfide-metabolizers are not yet available) as well as the applicable non-kith willing to devote 2 to 7 sidyears for a noble cause.

As a Save-the-Kildans volunteer, your food will be supplied, and you will be lodged on Kilda in specially designed floating accommodations. There, you will live alongside the Kildans, learning their language and transcribing the rich and ancient oral history of these, our most unique brethren race.

To apply, detach and complete the following form, and send it to the address listed below.

Thank you for your support,

KefKeff

Interim President, Save-the-Kildans Foundation

Save-the-Kildans
84 Mestone Ave. SW
Fenfra City, United Metanates
55021-192
Planet Qorral

Submission Guidelines

the floating liars' club is currently considering submissions of all forms of fiction, creative nonfiction, poetry, and artwork. The deadline for each issue is the 19th of the previous month. We pay two contributors copies upon publication. Email fiction submissions must be sent in plain text or rich text formats. Emailed graphics should be sent as thumbnail jpegs or gifs. Hard copy submissions should be mailed flat for anything larger than five pages. Do not send originals as we are unable to return manuscripts or artwork without special arrangement.

An additional benefit of publication is that your story will be illustrated with one or more graphics (subject to editorial considerations).

All submissions should be sent to:

floatingliarsclub@hotmail.com

or

Eveningland Publications
426 King Avenue, Suite 1-L
Columbus, OH 43201



Subscriptions & Back Issues

the floating liars' club

I would like to purchase a six-issue subscription for \$25.00 :

(fill in the number of subscriptions you would like to purchase)

- ☐ Begining with current issue or
☐ Begining the first issue (November 2002)

I would like to purchase the following back-issues for \$5.00 each.

(fill in the number of each issue you would like to purchase)

- ☐ October 2002 ☐ November 2002

Make all checks payable to
 Eveningland Publications care of Ben Crites

Send this form with check, or money order to:
426 King Avenue, Suite 1-L
Columbus, OH 43201

Advertise with *the floating liars' club*

the floating liars' club

\$15

Businesscard ads.



We offer larger ads at the same rate, and if you purchase a whole page, you get a \$20.00 discount.

I would like to purchase ____ business card ads for \$15.00 each.

I would like to purchase ____ full-page ads for \$100.00 each.

(attach business card, copy, or artwork below)

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Send this form with check, or money order to:
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Columbus, OH 43201

about the contributors

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the floating liars' club

Benjamin Crites

Born in a blizzard, Mr. Crites often marvels out his desk window, waiting for the snowstorm that will inevitably reclaim him. He's a news reporter here in Columbus. Find him slumped in plastic chairs at various school and city administration buildings, scribbling frenzied thoughts in spiral notebooks. He received his B.F.A. in Creative Writing from Bowling Green State University in 1999. All of his stories remind him of a pocketknife he lost in a mulch bed outside of his childhood home. Contact Ben at: ben_crites@yahoo.com

Nathan McKnight

Mauled by a typewriter at four, nasally impaled by a pencil at eight; hopes this magazine will not be the last round in his battle to the death with the writing profession. Inexplicably got a B.Sc. in Geology from OSU in 1999. Can be seen pacing naked in his apartment, pantomiming ctrl-F or teaching hands-on science (fully clothed) in South Central Columbus, Oh-High. aelffin@hotmail.com

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Jade

Because her circus was seized due to circuses being copyrighted by *Cirque du Soliel* she turned back to coloring. You can contact her at hit-esc@inorbit.com

Shannon Rampe

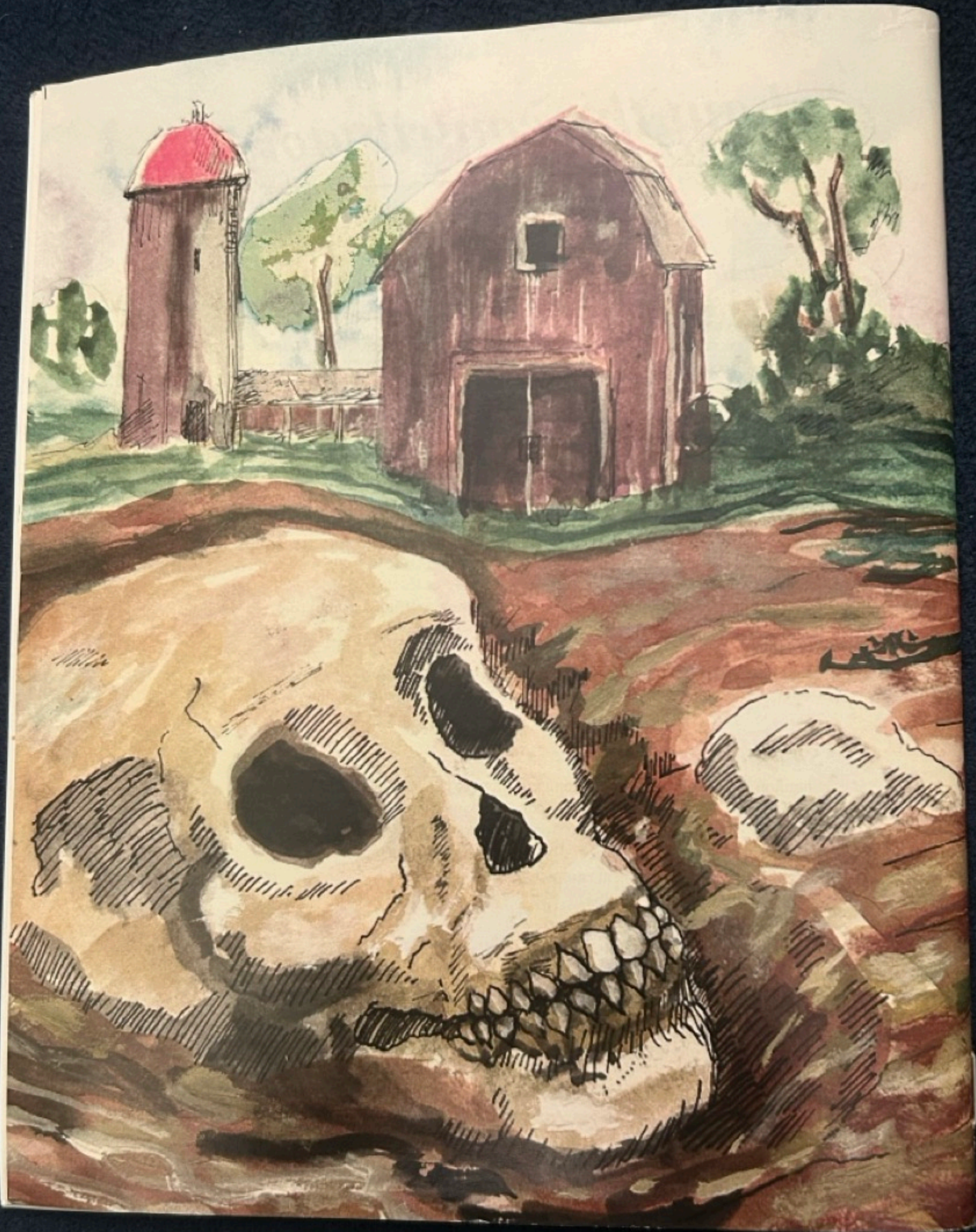
Shannon fancies himself a writer and is curious to talk writing or philosophy with anyone who is interested. He can be found smoking cigarettes in the back parking lot of the Lane Avenue Half Price Books. He would like to thank his friends and family for supporting him, especially Lauren, Jim Bowsher, and the Eveningland Writers' Group. Contact him at rampsputant@yahoo.com

Joseph Bellomy

He can't believe he spends so much time doing this. echoterra183@aol.com

For advertisement, subscriptions, submission guidelines, back issues, and general queries email floatingliarsclub@hotmail.com

january 2003

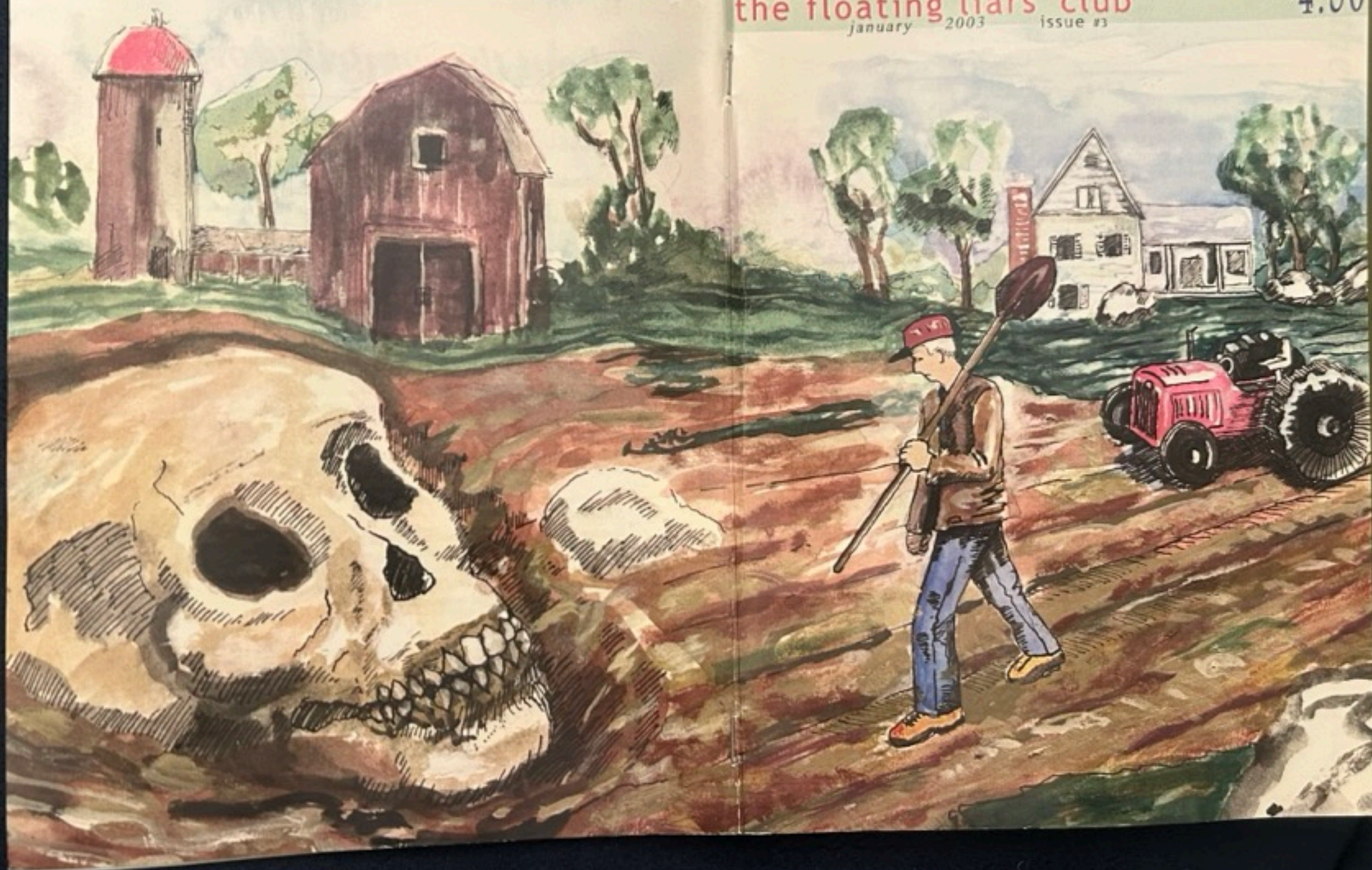


the floating liars' club

january 2003

issue #3

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shannon rampe - joe bellomy - ben criles - nathan mc knight - jade